

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Sculpture, Pottery and Iconography - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Sculpture, Pottery and Iconography	
REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST	
01	FOUNDATION — HOW TO READ SCULPTURE Evidence chain: Six-variable sculpture method Qualified use: Use the
02	FOUNDATION — LOST-WAX BRONZE AND HARAPPAN LABELS Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive
03	FOUNDATION — POTTERY AS CHRONOLOGICAL EVIDENCE NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early
04	CORE — YAKSHA AND AUSPICIOUS TREE FIGURES Evidence chain: Yaksha, Yakshi and Shalabhanjika Qualified use: Use
05	CORE — GANDHARA'S LAYERED IDIOM Evidence chain: Gandhara school Qualified use: Prepare the direct
06	CORE — MATHURA'S INDIGENOUS BREADTH Evidence chain: Mathura school Qualified use: Contrast material,
07	CORE — AMARAVATI'S NARRATIVE DYNAMISM Technically, CORE — Amaravati's narrative dynamism is analysed by
08	CORE — ANICONISM AND THE ICONIC SHIFT Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols
09	CORE — GUPTA RESTRAINT AND DATING LIMITS The Samath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for
10	CORE — NATARAJA FROM AIHOLE TO CHOLA Evidence chain: Nataraja origin and peak - Nataraja attribute system
11	CORE — LION AND BULL ACROSS MEDIA Evidence chain: Lion and bull programme - Nandi as architecture
12	CORE — NANDI, YALI AND VYALA Evidence chain: Nandi as architecture - Yali and Vyala distinction
13	CORE SYNTHESIS — SCULPTURE AS SOCIAL EVIDENCE Evidence chain: Temple sculpture as social evidence Qualified use:
14	CORE SYNTHESIS — TERRACOTTA'S LONG MATERIAL ARC Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to
15	CORE SYNTHESIS — VERIFIED PYQS AND FINAL ANSWER SPINE Evidence chain: Verified sculpture PYQ routes - Six-variable sculpture

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Sculpture, Pottery and Iconography - Learner-v2 Complete Learning Session

Authoring-only generation: 2026-09-01. No PDF was rendered and no tracker or index was mutated.

SOURCE, PROGRESSION AND CURRENT-LINKAGE AUDIT

- **Generation date:** 2026-09-01.
- **Repository-first evidence:** the Basic owner is taught first and preserved in full; the Advanced owner is retained only in the optional final teaching block.
- **OCR evidence:** Repository Markdown was primary. The available OCR-searchable Nitin Singhanian Indian Art and Culture PDF was retained as a supplementary source; no unsupported page precision, quotation or dynamic status was imported from it.
- **Qdrant:** not used; repository Markdown and available OCR context were sufficient.
- **PYQ integrity:** Three direct GS-I Mains demands are verified in the 2018-2023 routing ledger: 2019 Gandhara external elements, 2022 medieval temple sculpture as social evidence, and 2022 lion-bull significance. The 2026 empty-seat objective route has only a provisional key and is retained unsolved.
- **Live-link boundary:** No directly relevant live official item was verified for this topic on 2026-09-01. The package therefore says 'no verified live item' and does not invent a date, status, project or figure.
- **Fact/inference discipline:** no current-affairs item, PYQ wording, figure or quotation is invented.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

DEEP-REVIEW LEARNING CONTRACT

Control	Binding rule for this package
Syllabus boundary	Complete Indian Art and Culture Core is taught by form, chronology, region, patronage and function before optional enrichment.
Evidence method	Claim -> named monument/object/text/form/institution/community -> analysis -> qualification.
Chronology	Origin, surviving evidence, patronage phase, later adaptation, recognition and present status remain distinct.
Classification	Architecture, sculpture, painting, music, dance, theatre, language, craft, religion, heritage and cinema terms are compared on common axes without collapsing categories.
Interpretation	Style labels, iconographic readings, continuity, synthesis and social representation remain evidence-bounded rather than essentialist.
Practice contract	Every solved item has directive/demand decoding, a detailed examiner-grade model, executable compression plan, marks rationale and answer-specific improvement.
Approval	This immutable successor remains approved: false pending explicit approval.

Canonical Basic/Core owner: upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Indian-Art-and-Culture\basic\06_Sculpture-Pottery-and-Iconography.md **Canonical topic owner:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Indian-Art-and-Culture\basic\06_Sculpture-Pottery-and-Iconography.md **Optional Advanced owner:** upsc-ai-kit\kn

EVIDENCE, PYQ AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROL

- **Material evidence:** plans, fabric, technique, iconography, performance grammar, inscriptions, manuscripts, films and institutional records are identified before interpretation.
- **Attribution discipline:** patron, date, school, region, author, performer, community and function are stated only to the precision supported by the owner.
- **Quantitative discipline:** dimensions, counts, inscription years, lists, awards and registrations retain source, date, status and uncertainty; no figure is invented.
- **Interpretive discipline:** civilisational ranking, communal essentialism, timeless continuity, single-origin claims and treating commissioned representation as a social census are rejected.
- **PYQ discipline:** repository routing ledgers and locally held papers control wording and metadata; neutral rendering, reconstruction and unavailable official keys remain explicitly labelled.
- **Current-status note, rechecked 2026-09-01:** No directly relevant live official item was verified for this topic on 2026-09-01. The package therefore says 'no verified live item' and does not invent a date, status, project or figure.

Live/official context sources recorded by the predecessor generation:

- No live source is required for the static art-historical claim.



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

SESSION 1 - FOUNDATION - HOW TO READ SCULPTURE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Six-variable sculpture method Qualified use: Use the six variables as the method for the whole topic.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION
- How to read sculpture
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Read
- Description

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define How to read sculpture, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Read for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

HOW TO READ SCULPTURE

01. Six-variable sculpture method

BOUNDARY -> Description must connect form to evidence and its limits.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Description must connect form to evidence and its limits.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to How to read sculpture.
- **Mains:** Use the six variables as the method for the whole topic.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Six-variable sculpture method
- **Qualified use:** Use the six variables as the method for the whole topic.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - HOW TO READ SCULPTURE

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - How to read sculpture

|

v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION · How to read sculpture · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Read · Description

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Six-variable sculpture method Qualified use: Use the six variables as the method for the whole topic.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Mains: Use the six variables as the method for the whole topic.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: description must connect form to evidence and its limits.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

SESSION 2 - FOUNDATION - LOST-WAX BRONZE AND HARAPPAN LABELS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.

Technical definition: Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION
- Lost-wax bronze
- Harappan labels
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- In lost-wax casting a wax model

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define Lost-wax bronze, connect Harappan labels with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

LOST-WAX BRONZE AND HARAPPAN LABELS

01. Cire-perdue technique

|
v

02. Harappan label caution

BOUNDARY -> Technique is fact; object identity remains interpretive.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.
- Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Technique is fact; object identity remains interpretive.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Lost-wax bronze and Harappan labels.
- **Mains:** Separate secure manufacture from disputed meaning.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Cire-perdue technique -> Harappan label caution
- **Qualified use:** Separate secure manufacture from disputed meaning.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - LOST-WAX BRONZE AND HARAPPAN LABELS

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - Lost-wax bronze and Harappan labels

|
v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION • Lost-wax bronze • Harappan labels • Evidence chain • Qualified use • In lost-wax casting a wax model

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Cire-perdue technique - Harappan label caution Qualified use: Separate secure manufacture from disputed meaning.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: technique is fact; object identity remains interpretive.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.

SESSION 3 - FOUNDATION - POTTERY AS CHRONOLOGICAL EVIDENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: Pottery sequence - Northern Black Polished Ware Qualified use: Build a material-culture sequence.

Technical definition: NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Pottery sequence - Northern Black Polished Ware Qualified use: Build a material-culture sequence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **FOUNDATION**
- **Pottery as chronological evidence**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **NBPW**
- **Mauryan**

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define Pottery as chronological evidence, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use NBPW for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

POTTERY AS CHRONOLOGICAL EVIDENCE

01. Pottery sequence

|
v

02. Northern Black Polished Ware

BOUNDARY -> Harappan Red Ware, Black-and-Red Ware and NBPW are distinct.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware.
- NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Harappan Red Ware, Black-and-Red Ware and NBPW are distinct.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Pottery as chronological evidence.
- **Mains:** Build a material-culture sequence.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Pottery sequence -> Northern Black Polished Ware
- **Qualified use:** Build a material-culture sequence.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - POTTERY AS CHRONOLOGICAL EVIDENCE

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - Pottery as chronological evidence

|

v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION • Pottery as chronological evidence • Evidence chain • Qualified use • NBPW
• Mauryan

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Harappan Red Ware, Black-and-Red Ware and NBPW are distinct.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: nBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Pottery sequence - Northern Black Polished Ware
Qualified use: Build a material-culture sequence.

SESSION 4 - CORE - YAKSHA AND AUSPICIOUS TREE FIGURES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Yaksha, Yakshi and Shalabhanjika
Qualified use: Use motif continuity without claiming unchanged meaning.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Yaksha
- auspicious tree figures
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Yakshi
- Shalabhanjika

How to use them: Frame the answer through Yaksha; define auspicious tree figures, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Yakshi for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

YAKSHA AND AUSPICIOUS TREE FIGURES

01. Yaksha, Yakshi and Shalabhanjika

BOUNDARY -> Absorption across religions does not erase local cult roots.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Absorption across religions does not erase local cult roots.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Yaksha and auspicious tree figures.
- **Mains:** Use motif continuity without claiming unchanged meaning.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Yaksha, Yakshi and Shalabhanjika
- **Qualified use:** Use motif continuity without claiming unchanged meaning.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - YAKSHA AND AUSPICIOUS TREE FIGURES

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Yaksha and auspicious tree figures

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Yaksha · auspicious tree figures · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Yakshi · Shalabhanjika

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Yaksha, Yakshi and Shalabhanjika Qualified use: Use motif continuity without claiming unchanged meaning.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Absorption across religions does not erase local cult roots.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: use motif continuity without claiming unchanged meaning.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.

SESSION 5 - CORE - GANDHARA'S LAYERED IDIOM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Gandhara school Qualified use: Prepare the direct 2019 route.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Gandhara's layered idiom
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Gandhara
- Buddhist
- Hellenistic

How to use them: Frame the answer through Gandhara's layered idiom; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with Gandhara to explain the mechanism, and use Buddhist for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

GANDHARA'S LAYERED IDIOM

01. Gandhara school

BOUNDARY -> Name Greco-Bactrian and Central Asian strands separately.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Name Greco-Bactrian and Central Asian strands separately.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Gandhara's layered idiom.
- **Mains:** Prepare the direct 2019 route.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Gandhara school
- **Qualified use:** Prepare the direct 2019 route.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - GANDHARA'S LAYERED IDIOM

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Gandhara's layered idiom

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Gandhara's layered idiom • Evidence chain • Qualified use • Gandhara • Buddhist • Hellenistic

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Gandhara school Qualified use: Prepare the direct 2019 route.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose...

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.

SESSION 6 - CORE - MATHURA'S INDIGENOUS BREADTH

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Mathura school Qualified use: Contrast material, scope and attribute grammar.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Mathura's indigenous breadth
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Mathura
- Buddhist
- Hindu

How to use them: Frame the answer through Mathura's indigenous breadth; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with Mathura to explain the mechanism, and use Buddhist for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

MATHURA'S INDIGENOUS BREADTH

01. Mathura school

BOUNDARY -> Religious plurality is a key discriminator.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Religious plurality is a key discriminator.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Mathura's indigenous breadth.
- **Mains:** Contrast material, scope and attribute grammar.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Mathura school
- **Qualified use:** Contrast material, scope and attribute grammar.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - MATHURA'S INDIGENOUS BREADTH

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Mathura's indigenous breadth

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Mathura's indigenous breadth · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Mathura · Buddhist · Hindu

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Mathura school Qualified use: Contrast material, scope and attribute grammar.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Religious plurality is a key discriminator.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: contrast material, scope and attribute grammar.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

SESSION 7 - CORE - AMARAVATI'S NARRATIVE DYNAMISM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: Amaravati school Qualified use: Complete the three-school comparison.

Technical definition: Technically, CORE - Amaravati's narrative dynamism is analysed by relating Amaravati's narrative dynamism to Evidence chain, then testing the relationship through Qualified use and Gandhara's.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Do not borrow Gandhara's foreign-influence formula.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Amaravati's narrative dynamism
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Gandhara's
- Amaravati
- Qualified

How to use them: Frame the answer through Amaravati's narrative dynamism; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with Gandhara's to explain the mechanism, and use Amaravati for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

AMARAVATI'S NARRATIVE DYNAMISM

01. Amaravati school

BOUNDARY -> Do not borrow Gandhara's foreign-influence formula.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Do not borrow Gandhara's foreign-influence formula.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Amaravati's narrative dynamism.
- **Mains:** Complete the three-school comparison.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Amaravati school
- **Qualified use:** Complete the three-school comparison.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - AMARAVATI'S NARRATIVE DYNAMISM

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Amaravati's narrative dynamism

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Amaravati's narrative dynamism • Evidence chain • Qualified use • Gandhara's •
Amaravati • Qualified

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Amaravati school Qualified use: Complete the three-school comparison.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that do not borrow Gandhara's foreign-influence formula.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: do not borrow Gandhara's foreign-influence formula.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Do not borrow Gandhara's foreign-influence formula.

SESSION 8 - CORE - ANICONISM AND THE ICONIC SHIFT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: Aniconic symbolism - Parallel iconic shift Qualified use: Explain representational change cautiously.

Technical definition: Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Aniconic symbolism - Parallel iconic shift Qualified use: Explain representational change cautiously.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Aniconism**

- the iconic shift
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Early Buddhist
- Buddha

How to use them: Frame the answer through Aniconism; define the iconic shift, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Early Buddhist for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

ANICONISM AND THE ICONIC SHIFT

01. Aniconic symbolism

|

v

02. Parallel iconic shift

BOUNDARY -> A symbol is not absence, and priority remains debated.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure.
- Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A symbol is not absence, and priority remains debated.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Aniconism and the iconic shift.
- **Mains:** Explain representational change cautiously.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Aniconic symbolism -> Parallel iconic shift
- **Qualified use:** Explain representational change cautiously.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - ANICONISM AND THE ICONIC SHIFT

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Aniconism and the iconic shift

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Aniconism · the iconic shift · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Early Buddhist · Buddha

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: A symbol is not absence, and priority remains debated.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Aniconic symbolism - Parallel iconic shift Qualified use: Explain representational change cautiously.

SESSION 9 - CORE - GUPTA RESTRAINT AND DATING LIMITS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: Gupta Sarnath idiom Qualified use: Add a chronological bridge to southern sculpture.

Technical definition: The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Gupta Sarnath idiom Qualified use: Add a chronological bridge to southern sculpture.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Gupta restraint
- dating limits
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- The Sarnath
- Sultanganj

How to use them: Frame the answer through Gupta restraint; define dating limits, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use The Sarnath for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

GUPTA RESTRAINT AND DATING LIMITS

01. Gupta Sarnath idiom

BOUNDARY -> Late or post-Gupta is safer for Sultanganj.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Late or post-Gupta is safer for Sultanganj.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Gupta restraint and dating limits.
- **Mains:** Add a chronological bridge to southern sculpture.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Gupta Sarnath idiom
- **Qualified use:** Add a chronological bridge to southern sculpture.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - GUPTA RESTRAINT AND DATING LIMITS

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Gupta restraint and dating limits

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Gupta restraint • dating limits • Evidence chain • Qualified use • The Sarnath • Sultanganj

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Late or post-Gupta is safer for Sultanganj.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: add a chronological bridge to southern sculpture.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Gupta Sarnath idiom Qualified use: Add a chronological bridge to southern sculpture.

SESSION 10 - CORE - NATARAJA FROM AIHOLE TO CHOLA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: CORE - Nataraja from Aihole to Chola comprises Nataraja from Aihole to Chola, Evidence chain and Qualified use as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Nataraja origin and peak - Nataraja attribute system Qualified use: Build a full named-image answer.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Nataraja from Aihole to Chola
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner
- Nataraja
- Ravana Phadi

How to use them: Frame the answer through Nataraja from Aihole to Chola; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner to explain the mechanism, and use Nataraja for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

NATARAJA FROM AIHOLE TO CHOLA

01. Nataraja origin and peak

|
v

02. Nataraja attribute system

BOUNDARY -> Distinguish origin, peak and iconographic meaning.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it.
- Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Distinguish origin, peak and iconographic meaning.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Nataraja from Aihole to Chola.
- **Mains:** Build a full named-image answer.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Nataraja origin and peak -> Nataraja attribute system
- **Qualified use:** Build a full named-image answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - NATARAJA FROM AIHOLE TO CHOLA

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Nataraja from Aihole to Chola

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Nataraja from Aihole to Chola · Evidence chain · Qualified use · The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner · Nataraja · Ravana Phadi

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Nataraja origin and peak - Nataraja attribute system
Qualified use: Build a full named-image answer.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: mains: Build a full named-image answer.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it.

SESSION 11 - CORE - LION AND BULL ACROSS MEDIA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Lion and bull programme - Nandi as architecture Qualified use: Prepare the direct 2022 animal-symbol route.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Lion
- bull across media
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- At Shaiva temples the bull
- At Shaiva

How to use them: Frame the answer through Lion; define bull across media, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use At Shaiva temples the bull for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

LION AND BULL ACROSS MEDIA

01. Lion and bull programme

|
v

02. Nandi as architecture

BOUNDARY -> Keep Harappan, Buddhist and imperial claims source-separated.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system.
- At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Keep Harappan, Buddhist and imperial claims source-separated.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Lion and bull across media.
- **Mains:** Prepare the direct 2022 animal-symbol route.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Lion and bull programme -> Nandi as architecture
- **Qualified use:** Prepare the direct 2022 animal-symbol route.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - LION AND BULL ACROSS MEDIA

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Lion and bull across media

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Lion · bull across media · Evidence chain · Qualified use · At Shaiva temples the bull · At Shaiva

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Lion and bull programme - Nandi as architecture Qualified use: Prepare the direct 2022 animal-symbol route.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that at Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: at Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

SESSION 12 - CORE - NANDI, YALI AND VYALA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Nandi as architecture - Yali and Vyala distinction Qualified use: Link iconography to temple planning.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Nandi
- Yali
- Vyala
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- At Shaiva temples the bull

How to use them: Frame the answer through Nandi; define Yali, connect Vyala with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

NANDI, YALI AND VYALA

01. Nandi as architecture

|
v

02. Yali and Vyala distinction

BOUNDARY -> Placed architecture and hybrid ornament solve different problems.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.
- Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Placed architecture and hybrid ornament solve different problems.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Nandi, Yali and Vyala.
- **Mains:** Link iconography to temple planning.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Nandi as architecture -> Yali and Vyala distinction
- **Qualified use:** Link iconography to temple planning.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - NANDI, YALI AND VYALA

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Nandi, Yali and Vyala

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Nandi • Yali • Vyala • Evidence chain • Qualified use • At Shaiva temples the bull

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Nandi as architecture - Yali and Vyala distinction Qualified use: Link iconography to temple planning.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies.

SESSION 13 - CORE SYNTHESIS - SCULPTURE AS SOCIAL EVIDENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Commissioned visibility is not representative social data.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Temple sculpture as social evidence Qualified use: Prepare the direct 2022 social-life route.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Temple sculpture as social evidence Qualified use: Prepare the direct 2022 social-life route.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **CORE SYNTHESIS**
- **Sculpture as social evidence**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **Dancers**
- **Commissioned visibility**

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Sculpture as social evidence, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Dancers for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

SCULPTURE AS SOCIAL EVIDENCE

01. Temple sculpture as social evidence

BOUNDARY -> Commissioned visibility is not representative social data.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Commissioned visibility is not representative social data.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Sculpture as social evidence.
- **Mains:** Prepare the direct 2022 social-life route.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Temple sculpture as social evidence
- **Qualified use:** Prepare the direct 2022 social-life route.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - SCULPTURE AS SOCIAL EVIDENCE

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Sculpture as social evidence

|

v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · Sculpture as social evidence · Evidence chain · Qualified use ·
Dancers · Commissioned visibility

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Commissioned visibility is not representative social data.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: temple sculpture as social evidence
Qualified use.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Temple sculpture as social evidence Qualified use:
Prepare the direct 2022 social-life route.

SESSION 14 - CORE SYNTHESIS - TERRACOTTA'S LONG MATERIAL ARC

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: Terracotta continuity Qualified use: Add the pottery and living-material dimension.

Technical definition: Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketurah craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Terracotta continuity Qualified use: Add the pottery and living-material dimension.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- Terracotta's long material arc
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Terracotta
- Harappan

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Terracotta's long material arc, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Terracotta for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

TERRACOTTA'S LONG MATERIAL ARC

01. Terracotta continuity

BOUNDARY -> Object continuity does not prove unchanged community or meaning.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Object continuity does not prove unchanged community or meaning.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Terracotta's long material arc.
- **Mains:** Add the pottery and living-material dimension.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Terracotta continuity
- **Qualified use:** Add the pottery and living-material dimension.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - TERRACOTTA'S LONG MATERIAL ARC

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Terracotta's long material arc

|
v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS • Terracotta's long material arc • Evidence chain • Qualified use •
Terracotta • Harappan

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that add the pottery and living-material dimension.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Object continuity does not prove unchanged community or meaning.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Terracotta continuity Qualified use: Add the pottery and living-material dimension.

SESSION 15 - CORE SYNTHESIS - VERIFIED PYQS AND FINAL ANSWER SPINE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: ANALYSIS: Analytical spine (the argument, not the list): terracotta is the only Indian medium that is simultaneously the cheapest, the most widely distributed, the least durable in the open and the most continuously practised.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Verified sculpture PYQ routes - Six-variable sculpture method Qualified use: Integrate method, evidence, comparison and qualification.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

ANALYSIS: Analytical spine (the argument, not the list): terracotta is the only Indian medium that is simultaneously the cheapest, the most widely distributed, the least durable in the open and the most continuously practised.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- Verified PYQs
- final answer spine
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Subject

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Verified PYQs, connect final answer spine with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

VERIFIED PYQS AND FINAL ANSWER SPINE

01. Verified sculpture PYQ routes

|
v

02. Six-variable sculpture method

BOUNDARY -> Do not solve the provisional 2026 objective route.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance.
- Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Do not solve the provisional 2026 objective route.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact form, region, text, technique or institution attached to Verified PYQs and final answer spine.
- **Mains:** Integrate method, evidence, comparison and qualification.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Verified sculpture PYQ routes -> Six-variable sculpture method
- **Qualified use:** Integrate method, evidence, comparison and qualification.

COMPLETE BASIC OWNER EVIDENCE BANK

Subject: Indian Art & Culture | **Tier:** Must-Do (foundation) | **GS Paper:** GS-I. **Core area:** Harappan seals/bronzes/pottery; Mauryan Yaksha-Yakshi; Gandhara-Mathura-Amaravati schools; Gupta sculpture; South Indian temple sculpture; Chola Nataraja bronze; Mughal sculpture. **Grounded in:** Nitin Singhania, *Indian Art and Culture*, PDF pp. 189-218; R.S. Sharma, *India's Ancient Past*, PDF pp. 211-223, 347-355; R.S. Sharma, *Ancient India*, PDF pp. 121-123, 156-159; 00_Master-Framework.md Sections 2-3; audited UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper I (supports Topic 03's direct question). **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = analytical inference | **CURRENT:** = current anchor | **WRONG:** = trap. *Companion:* advanced/06_Sculpture-Pottery-and-Iconography.md.

1. Snapshot and syllabus fit

FACT: This topic covers sculpture and pottery from the Harappan civilisation through the Mughal period, and supplies the iconographic vocabulary (mudras, Nataraja, Yaksha-Yakshi) that the 2025 Chandella-sculpture PYQ (owned by topic 03) directly requires. **ANALYSIS:** No PYQ tests this topic in isolation, but it is inseparable from any temple-architecture or iconography question.

2. Essential vocabulary

Term	Exam-ready meaning
FACT: Cire-perdue (lost-wax) technique	Bronze-casting method known since the Indus Valley period: wax figure coated in clay, heated to melt out the wax, then filled with molten metal (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 190, 195).
FACT: Yaksha/Yakshi	Folk deities/nature spirits connected with water, fertility, trees and wilderness, absorbed into Vedic, Buddhist, Jain and Hindu worship; Yakshi is the female counterpart, associated with fertility (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 197-198).
FACT: Shalabhanjika	A yakshi-holding-a-tree motif, common as a bracket figure on stupa gateways (Sanchi, Bharhut) and later in Hoysala temples; symbolises fertility and auspiciousness (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 198-199).
FACT: Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW)	Fine, highly lustrous tableware, often black/steel-grey but also other shades; associated especially with early historic urbanisation, not exclusively the Mauryan court.
FACT: Kirtimukha	A monster-faced decorative motif common in South Indian temple iconography, also found in Buddhist architecture (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF p. 208).
FACT: Nataraja	Shiva as the Lord of Dance in Tandava posture; a defining Chola sculptural icon, though its earliest known example is at the Ravana Phadi Cave, Aihole (early Chalukya period) (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 210-211).

3. Core classification

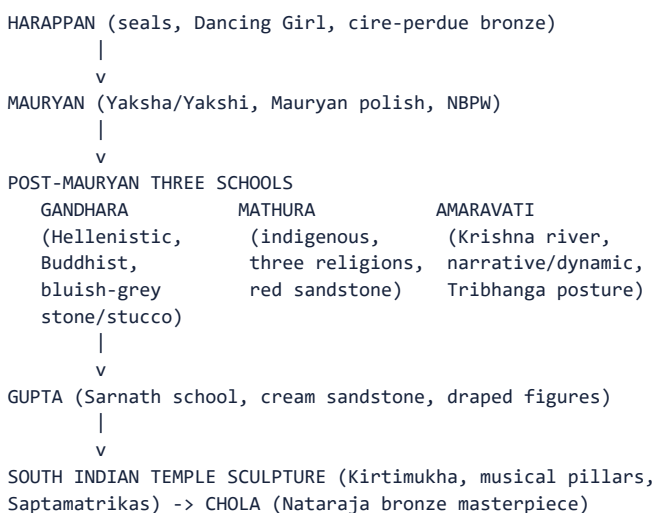
FACT: Post-Mauryan sculpture developed through **three regional schools:** **Gandhara** (Greek/Hellenistic-influenced, Buddhist, bluish-grey sandstone/stucco), **Mathura** (indigenous, all-three-religions, red sandstone), and **Amaravati** (Krishna river basin, dynamic/narrative Tribhanga-posture art, also called the Vengi School) (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 200-204). **FACT:** Harappan pottery is predominantly red ware, often painted in black, with plain and painted varieties; it should not be collapsed into the separate, wider archaeological category "Black-and-Red Ware." Pottery traditions proceed chronologically from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted ware (Ahar, Malwa, Jorwe), Harappan Red Ware, Painted Grey Ware (Vedic age), to Mauryan NBPW (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 194, 199).

4. Foundation narrative

FACT: Famous Harappan objects: the so-called **Pashupati Seal** (steatite, Mohenjo-daro, a horned seated figure whose proto-Shiva identification R.S. Sharma explicitly calls doubtful); the **Dancing Girl** (one of the earliest celebrated South Asian lost-wax bronzes, often described through the later term tribhanga); terracotta female figures, whose automatic "Mother Goddess" label is interpretive rather than certain; and the **Bearded Priest** (steatite, Mohenjo-daro) (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 191-193). FACT: The **Didarganj Chauri-bearer/Yakshi** (often dated Mauryan, but also assigned by scholars to later centuries) and the **Parkham Yaksha** exemplify Mauryan-period Yaksha/Yakshi sculpture, carrying the characteristic Mauryan polish (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 197-198). FACT: Gandhara and Mathura both participated, around the early centuries CE, in the shift toward anthropomorphic Buddha images; priority between them is debated, so "Gandhara first" should not be stated as settled. Earlier Buddhist monuments often used symbolic representation (footprint, throne, wheel, tree); Greco-Roman influence shows in wavy hair, slender musculature, pleated garments, and elongated earlobes (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 201-202). FACT: The Mathura school used avayudhas (attribute-symbols) to represent Hindu gods (e.g. Shiva through linga) and depicted Buddha largely in Abhaya Mudra, with a larger, geometrically decorated halo than Gandhara (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF p. 203). FACT: Gupta and immediately post-Gupta sculpture developed around Sarnath, using cream-coloured sandstone and metal, with subtly modelled, thinly draped figures. The c. seventh-century Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late/post-Gupta rather than an uncontested Gupta-period work.

FACT: **Nataraja iconography (Chola)**: rear right hand holds the damaru (creation-sound); rear left hand holds fire (destruction); front right hand in Abhaya Mudra (reassurance); the front left hand points toward the upraised foot to indicate the path of salvation, in the pose called **Gajahasta** ("elephant hand"); the left leg in the **bhujangatrāsita** stance represents *tirobhava*, kicking away the veil of maya from the devotee's mind; the supporting foot subdues the dwarf Apasmara/Muyalaka (ignorance/forgetfulness); matted locks may include the Ganga motif; one male and one female earring represent Ardhanarishvara fusion; a snake symbolises dormant kundalini power; a surrounding nimbus represents unending time cycles (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 211-212). FACT: Many South Indian Shiva temples keep a separate **natana-sabha** for the Nataraja image; the book's named comparative set is the Chidambaram Chola bronze masterpiece, stone reliefs in Pallava cave temples, panels on Hoysala temple walls and the Thanjavur Brihadeeswara Nataraja (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF p. 212). FACT: The **earliest known Nataraja sculpture** was excavated at the Ravana Phadi Cave, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule - **before** it reached its peak development under the Cholas (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF p. 211) - an important chronological correction to any answer assuming Nataraja iconography originated with the Cholas.

5. Visual map or comparison table



School	External influence	Material	Religious scope
FACT: Gandhara	Heavy Greek/Hellenistic (also called Indo-Greek art)	Bluish-grey sandstone; later stucco	Mainly Buddhist
FACT: Mathura	Indigenous development	Spotted red sandstone	Buddhism, Hinduism, Jainism
FACT: Amaravati (Vengi School)	Indigenous, narrative-focused	Local stone, dynamic reliefs	Mainly Buddhist

Reading problem	Safe formulation
Pashupati seal	"Horned seated figure, often interpreted as proto-Shiva; identification disputed"
Didarganj figure	"Chauri-bearer traditionally dated Mauryan; chronology debated"
First Buddha image	"Gandhara and Mathura developed anthropomorphic Buddha imagery in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts"
Nataraja	"Pre-Chola antecedents, including Aihole; Chola bronzes achieved canonical portable form"

6. Source spine

FACT: *Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 189-214 (Chapter 3, "Sculpture and Pottery" - full chapter), the direct spine for Sections 2-4.

7. Exact PYQ application

FACT: **2025 Q3 (Chandella sculpture), supported by this topic:** while Topic 03 owns the direct answer, this topic supplies the **iconographic reading method** - reading posture, gesture, material and comparative motif (as applied to Nataraja above) - that a strong answer on "resilient vigour and breadth of life" in Chandella sculpture should also apply to Khajuraho's figural corpus. ANALYSIS: No Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers tests sculpture/pottery/iconography as a stand-alone topic.

8. CURRENT: Current anchor

- CURRENT: ASI's conservation mandate explicitly extends to sculptures (loose and in-situ) alongside monuments and paintings; verify any claim about a specific sculpture's current conservation or display status (e.g. museum relocation) against ASI's or the relevant museum's own dated release - see topic 14.

9. WRONG: Traps and corrections

- WRONG: The Nataraja iconography originated with the Cholas. -> The book is explicit that its earliest known example is at Aihole's Ravana Phadi Cave under the early Chalukyas; the Cholas brought it to its peak, not its origin.

- WRONG: Gandhara unquestionably made the first human Buddha image. -> R.S. Sharma records both Gandhara and Mathura production in the Kushana age; priority remains debated.

- WRONG: "Mother Goddess," "Priest-King" and "Pashupati" are deciphered Harappan identities. -> These are modern labels/interpretations; the script remains undeciphered.

- FACT: **Local PYQ routes:** CSE 2019 asks for Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara; CSE 2022 asks the significance of lion and bull figures. Both reward material, context and symbol distinctions rather than one-line labels.

- WRONG: Gandhara art is purely Greek art relocated to India. -> It combines Parthian, Central Asian/Bactrian and Greco-Roman influences layered over a Buddhist iconographic programme - "Indo-Greek" is a shorthand, not a literal equivalence.

- WRONG: Mathura school sculpture was religiously exclusive to one faith. -> It was influenced by "all three religions of the time" - Buddhism, Hinduism and Jainism.

- WRONG: All Harappan sculpture is crude/unrefined. -> The Dancing Girl and

Pashupati seal show sophisticated technique (lost-wax casting, fine steatite carving), even though some terracotta figures are comparatively crude.

- WRONG: Harappan painted pottery is simply "Black-and-Red Ware." -> Most

Harappan pottery is red ware with black-painted designs; Black-and-Red Ware is a separate technical category found in several cultures.

10. Mains framework

1. Identify the specific school/period before describing any sculpture.
2. Use precise iconographic vocabulary (mudra names, motif names) rather than generic description.
3. Where a question invites comparison (e.g. Gandhara vs. Mathura), use the material/influence/religious-scope table (Section 5) as the answer's spine.
4. Apply the Nataraja iconographic-reading method to any other named sculpture (e.g. Khajuraho figures, topic 03) for a comparative, higher-scoring answer.
5. Close with a current conservation/display status line where relevant, cross-referenced to topic 14.

11. Boundaries with other subjects

- WRONG: **Ancient History owns** the political chronology of the Mauryan, Shunga, Kushana and Gupta periods. This file owns the **sculptural form, technique and iconography** produced under their patronage.
- WRONG: **Topic 13 owns** the doctrinal significance of Hindu/Buddhist/Jain iconography as religious philosophy. This file reads iconography as **art-historical evidence** of belief and patronage, not as theology.
- FACT: Cross-links: Topic 02 (the monuments where much of this sculpture is found), Topic 03 (Chandella and Chola sculptural programmes), Topic 09 (shared postures/mudras between sculpture and classical dance).

12. Companion links

- FACT: Advanced companion: advanced/06_Sculpture-Pottery-and-Iconography.md.
- FACT: 00_Master-Framework.md Section 2 - the "how to read a monument or artwork" method reused here.
- ANALYSIS: **Cross-links:** Topic 02 (rock-cut monuments housing this sculpture), Topic 03 (Chandella/Chola sculptural programmes), Topic 09 (dance- sculpture posture parallels).

13. Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

Core-sufficiency note. This topic supplies the reading method that the **2025 Chandella sculpture question** and the **2024 Chola question** both need, and independently owns recurring school-comparison, iconographic-identification and aniconic-symbolism demands. Nothing here requires advanced/06.

13.0 Direct Mains demands owned by this Core file

Core routing supersedes older advanced/ pointers (final pass, 2026-08-13). The controlling ledger _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md routes three GS-I Mains demands to advanced/06. All three are now answerable **from this Core file alone**, and Core is the owner of record; the Advanced pointers are legacy and are not required.

Year	Verbatim routed demand	Directive · marks	FACT: Core section that answers it
2019	Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art	Highlight · 10 · 150 words	§13.6B (+ §13.5)
2022	Medieval Indian temple sculptures as evidence of social life	How will you explain · 10 · 150 words	§13.6C (+ §13.4, §13.8); register bank in basic/03 §13.10
2022	Lion and bull figures in Indian mythology, art and architecture	Discuss the significance · 15 · 250 words	§13.6A (+ basic/02 §13.6C, basic/03 §13.9A)

ANALYSIS: **Two of these three were not answerable from Core before this pass.** The **2019 Gandhara** demand needed the two external strands separated by name (§13.6B), and the **2022 lion-and-bull** demand had no evidence bank anywhere in the folder (§13.6A). **WRONG:** Do not treat a routed demand as covered because a ledger points at it; only a named Core section is coverage.

13.1 Directive and demand map

If the question says	It is really testing	Do NOT write
<i>Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art</i>	Layered external influence over a Buddhist iconographic programme	"Gandhara art is Greek art in India"
<i>Compare the Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati schools</i>	Material, influence, religious scope, treatment and format, school by school	Three separate paragraphs with no axis of comparison
<i>Discuss the significance of animal figures (lion, bull, elephant) in Indian art</i>	Symbol -> context -> function, across religions and periods	A list of animals with one-word meanings
<i>Medieval temple sculpture as evidence of social life</i>	Secular registers read as patron-selected representation	Treating carvings as photographs
<i>Explain the iconography of a named image</i>	The systematic attribute-by-attribute method (as for Nataraja)	Generic admiration
<i>Trace the shift from symbolic to human representation of the Buddha</i>	Aniconic symbol set -> early anthropomorphic images -> the priority debate	"Gandhara made the first Buddha image"
<i>Sculpture and technique</i>	Material determining what carving or casting can achieve (cire-perdue, stone type, stucco)	Ignoring material entirely

13.2 Qualified thesis options

- ANALYSIS: **Method thesis (most transferable):** "Any Indian sculpture can be read through six variables - material, posture and gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison - and an answer that applies them in order will outperform one that describes appearance."
- ANALYSIS: **Influence thesis:** "Gandhara is best described as a Buddhist iconographic programme executed in a Hellenised visual idiom under Kushana patronage - the subject is Indian, the surface treatment is borrowed, and calling it 'Greek art' inverts the relationship."
- ANALYSIS: **Parallel-development thesis:** "Anthropomorphic Buddha imagery emerged in broadly overlapping early-centuries-CE contexts at both Gandhara and Mathura; priority is disputed, and the exam-safe position is parallel development rather than a single origin."
- ANALYSIS: **Peak-not-origin thesis:** "Chola bronzes perfected rather than invented the Nataraja: the earliest known example is at Aihole under early Chalukya rule, and what the Cholas contributed was the canonical, portable, ritually processional form."
- ANALYSIS: **Material thesis:** "Material is not a background detail: cire-perdue bronze permits the free limbs and open silhouette of the Nataraja, and fine-grained sandstone permits the deep undercutting of Khajuraho's figures - technique makes the aesthetic possible."

13.3 Mark-scaled structures

Marks	Structure
10	Thesis -> school or image identified -> two or three named attributes/features with meaning -> one comparison -> one caution -> verdict
10 (2019 Gandhara route)	Run §13.6B end to end: thesis (Indian subject, Hellenised idiom, Kushana patronage) -> Greco-Bactrian elements named (wavy hair, modelled musculature, pleated drapery, bluish-grey sandstone/stucco) -> Central Asian strand named separately (Kushana patronage, Parthian/Bactrian layering) -> the Indian core that was not borrowed -> one Mathura contrast -> outward diffusion -> verdict
10 (2022 social-life route)	Run §13.6C: claim -> two or three named registers from basic/03 §13.10 -> the six-variable method applied to one of them -> the commissioned-representation qualification -> verdict
15	Thesis -> the six-variable method named -> two schools compared on material/influence/scope -> one iconographic worked example -> chronological correction (Aihole/Chola or Gandhara/Mathura) -> verdict
15 (2022 lion-and-bull route)	Run §13.6A's nine-step structure: thesis of two functions -> bounded mythology leg -> Harappan art leg with the undeciphered-script caution -> Buddhist leg (Rampurva pair, Sarnath abacus) -> bull architecture (Nandi mandapas) -> lion architecture (Yali/Vyala) -> change over time -> source qualification -> national-emblem verdict
20	All of the above -> plus the pottery/material-culture sequence -> aniconic-to-iconic shift -> social-history reading with its limits -> conservation/display status caution -> verdict answering the exact wording

13.4 Evidence bank A - the six-variable reading method (with a worked application)

Variable	Question to ask	FACT: Worked example - Chandella/Khajuraho figures (for 2025 Q3, owned by topic 03)
Material	What does the medium permit?	Fine-grained sandstone permits deep, precise relief and undercutting
Posture/gesture	Static or dynamic; what does the body do?	Flexed, twisting, interacting figures - dancers, musicians, mithuna couples - rather than frontal static poses
Iconographic attribute	Which specific motif recurs?	Vyalas - hybrid lion-bodied imaginary animals - a named motif, not generic "animal ornament"
Patron	Who commissioned it and why?	Chandella royal and elite patronage under a newly independent dynasty (topic 03)
Site context	Where is it placed and who sees it?	Open, unwallled platform terraces, unlike the walled Dravida enclosure
Cross-site comparison	What does it resemble and differ from?	Comparable in density to Hoysala friezes, different in programme from Chola bronze icon-making

ANALYSIS: The same six columns can be re-run for a Gandhara Buddha, a Chola Nataraja, a Mauryan yaksha or an unfamiliar image in a future paper - this is the file's main future-question insurance.

13.5 Evidence bank B - school comparison (Gandhara / Mathura / Amaravati)

Axis	FACT: Gandhara	FACT: Mathura	FACT: Amaravati (Vengi)
External influence	Heavy Greek/Hellenistic, layered with Parthian and Central Asian/Bactrian elements	Indigenous development	FACT: "Developed on purely indigenous lines with no foreign influence" (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF p. 301)
Material	Bluish-grey sandstone; later stucco	Spotted red sandstone	Greenish-white limestone
Religious scope	Mainly Buddhist	Buddhism, Hinduism and Jainism	Mainly Buddhist
Treatment	Wavy hair, slender musculature, pleated garments, elongated earlobes; composed stillness	Avayudhas (attribute-symbols) for Hindu deities; Buddha largely in Abhaya Mudra; larger geometrically decorated halo	FACT: Narrative art - relief medallions telling whole episodes (e.g. the Buddha taming an elephant); Tribhanga posture used extensively
Patronage	Kushana	Kushana and successors	FACT: Satavahana, later also Ikshvaku (3rd-4th century AD)
Diffusion	Central Asian and East Asian transmission	Pan-north Indian	FACT: A Buddha image with robe on the left shoulder and the other hand in Abhaya mudra became iconic and was replicated across South and Southeast Asia

(*Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 200-205, 299-301.) ANALYSIS: **Answer rule:** compare along a named axis - influence, material, scope, treatment, patronage, diffusion - never as three descriptive blocks.

13.6 Evidence bank C - aniconic symbolism and the iconic shift

- FACT: **The symbol set, event by event** (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF p. 776): birth -

bull, elephant, lotus, footprint; great renunciation - horse, empty throne, begging bowl; enlightenment - vajrasana, Bodhi tree; sermons - wheel, lion, deer; death/parinirvana - stupa.

- FACT: **The rule to state:** "The early Buddhist sculptors did not show

Buddha in human form. They indicated Buddha's presence through Empty Throne, Bodhi Tree, Wheel, Stupa - indicating four important events (renunciation, enlightenment, first sermon, death) in the life of Buddha" (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF p. 776). FACT: The book separately records representation "by his footprint, his throne, and his..." symbols at PDF p. 201, and notes at PDF p. 53 that idols of the Buddha were carved later.

- ANALYSIS: **Analytical significance:** the empty seat is not an absence but a *presence-marker*; it records a doctrinal reluctance to embody the Buddha, and the later human image marks a change in devotional practice, not merely in artistic skill.

- WRONG: **Priority caution:** do not state that Gandhara made the first human

Buddha image; R.S. Sharma records both Gandhara and Mathura production in the Kushana age and priority remains debated.

13.6A Evidence bank C+ - the lion and the bull: mythology, art and architecture (the direct 2022 GS-I 15-mark route)

Direct Mains route, promoted to Core (final pass, 2026-08-13). CSE 2022 GS-I Q13 - "Discuss the significance of the lion and bull figures in Indian mythology, art and architecture" (15 marks · 250 words). The controlling ledger _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md pointed this demand at advanced/06. **Core routing now supersedes that pointer:** this file is the substantive owner, supported by basic/02 (Mauryan pillars, Buddhist symbolism) and basic/03 (Nandi, Yali, Vyala in temple programmes). No advanced/ file is required. ANALYSIS: **The question has three legs and they must be kept separate**, because the evidence for each is of a different kind: **mythology** (textual and devotional association), **art** (sculpture, seals, relief, symbol) and **architecture** (structural and programmatic placement). An answer that merges them into "animals were important in Indian culture" scores as a list.

A. The single strongest evidence unit - Rampurva, where the lion and the bull stand side by side

- FACT: ***In Rampurva, there are two Ashokan pillars found (one with a lion capital and one with a bull capital). The lion capital pillar is inscribed with the Major Pillar Edicts I to VI. However, the bull capital pillar does not have inscriptions" (Nitin...pdf, PDF pp. 233-234). **Rampurva (Bihar) is one of the seven**** locations of the Major Pillar Edicts (PDF p. 233).

- ANALYSIS: **Why this is the best single unit in the whole answer:** one site, one patron, one period, **two animals, two different functions**. The **lion** carries the imperial-political message and the **edict text**; the **bull** carries none. The inscription distinction is a *fact*, not an inference, and it lets the answer argue that the two animals were not interchangeable decorative choices - the lion was recruited to speak, the bull was not.

- WRONG: **Do not** say the Rampurva bull pillar is "uninscribed because it is earlier," or assign it to a non-Ashokan dynasty; the source states only that it lacks inscriptions.

B. The Sarnath abacus - the lion and the bull inside one programme

FACT: Element	FACT: Sourced content (Nitin...pdf, PDF pp. 42-44)	Analytical use
Capital	Four lions standing back-to-back on a circular abacus , with bull, horse, lion and elephant carvings and the Dharmachakra	The lion appears twice - as the crowning figure <i>and</i> as one of the four abacus animals; the bull appears once, as an abacus animal
Directions	Abacus animals represent four directions - galloping horse (west), elephant (east), bull (south), lion (north) ; they "seem to follow each other turning the wheel of existence till eternity"	A cosmological reading, not a menagerie: the animals are a <i>system</i>
Biographical meanings	Elephant = the dream of Queen Maya , a white elephant entering her womb; Bull = the zodiac sign of Taurus , the month in which Buddha was born ; Horse = Kanthaka , used to leave the princely life; Lion = the attainment of enlightenment	The decisive line for this question: within one capital, the bull marks birth and the lion marks enlightenment - beginning and culmination of the same life
The four lions	Symbolise Buddha spreading Dharma in all directions ; built in commemoration of the first sermon, Dharmachakrapravartana	Lion = the <i>voice</i> of doctrine (cf. the Buddha as "lion of the Shakyas" is not in this source - do not add it)
Modern status	The abacus and the animal part form the official national emblem of India , adopted 26 January 1950 ; Satyameva Jayate , from the Mundaka Upanishad , is inscribed below the abacus in Devanagari; the capital is crowned by the Dharma Chakra	Converts a mythology question into a living-symbol conclusion - the strongest available closing move
Comparators	Vaishali (Kolhua): single lion capital, no abacus , with Major Pillar Edict VI. Sanchi : four lions back-to-back like Sarnath but a flatter abacus with alternating pairs of geese and flame palmettes , c. 250 BC , carrying the Schism Edict and a later Gupta Sankha Lipi inscription (PDF pp. 43, 47)	Shows the lion capital as a repeated imperial type with local variation - evidence of a programme, not a one-off

C. Buddhist aniconic meaning - the bull as a birth symbol

- FACT: In the aniconic symbol set, the **birth** of the Buddha is indicated by **bull, elephant, lotus and footprint**; the **sermons** by **wheel, lion and deer** (Nitin...pdf, PDF p. 776; §13.6 above).

- ANALYSIS: **Analytical use:** this is independent corroboration of the Sarnath reading - in a tradition that refused to show the Buddha's body, the **bull stood in for birth** and the **lion for preaching**. Two media (pillar capital and narrative relief), one consistent code.

- WRONG: Do not claim the aniconic phase "prohibited" animal imagery; what it avoided was the **human figure of the Buddha** (§13.6).

D. Harappan evidence - with the archaeological caution stated, not hidden

- FACT: **The seal corpus:** common animal motifs include a ****unicorn, humped bull, rhinoceros, tiger, elephant, buffalo, bison, goat, markhor, ibex and crocodile;** "no evidence of cow and lion has been found on any seal" (**Nitin...pdf, PDF p. 191**). FACT: **The famous seals named by the source are the Pashupati Seal and the Unicorn Seal**.**
- FACT: **A second Harappan bull object:** the **bronze bull of Kalibangan**, cast by the **cire-perdue (lost-wax)** method known from the Indus period (PDF p. 193).
- ANALYSIS: **Caution that earns marks:** the humped bull (zebu) is *frequent* on Harappan seals, but the script is **undeciphered** and "Pashupati," "Mother Goddess" and "Priest-King" are **modern labels** (§13.7). So the honest formulation is: **the bull was a privileged image in Harappan visual culture; what it meant to Harappans cannot be recovered, and later Shaiva meaning must not be read backwards into it.**
- WRONG: **The high-value trap:** the **lion is absent** from the Harappan seal corpus while the **bull is prominent** - so the lion's Indian career, on this evidence, begins **later** and is tied to **imperial and royal** usage, not to the earliest urban civilisation. ANALYSIS: Note also that **cow** is absent, which is why "Cow" is the correct answer to the reproduced CSE 2001 item asking which animal was **not** represented in Harappan seals and terracotta (PDF p. 184).

E. The bull in Hindu architecture - Nandi as a placed, structural figure

FACT: Named case	FACT: Sourced content	Architectural point
Brihadishvara, Thanjavur	A big Nandi Mandap in front of the temple with a massive monolithic Nandi, the second largest in the country (<i>Nitin...pdf, PDF p. 91</i>)	The bull is given its own building , on the temple's axis - the clearest proof that it is architecture, not ornament
Lepakshi Veerabhadra, Andhra Pradesh	Holds the largest monolithic Nandi (bull) in the country (PDF p. 329)	Gives the answer a superlative pair (largest / second largest) that is source-checked
Kailasa, Ellora (Cave 16)	Two-storeyed temple housing a shivalingam, with a Nandi mandapa and two flagstaff pillars in the courtyard (PDF p. 61)	The same axial arrangement executed monolithically , by excavation rather than construction (basic/02)
Ramappa, Kakatiya	A monolithic Nandi within the premises; the main temple stands in front of the Nandi Pavilion (PDF pp. 107, 109)	Shows the arrangement persisting into the 13th century and into a UNESCO-listed property (basic/14 §13.8A)
Hoysala (Somanathapura group)	The Nandi Pavilion and a separate kalyani (temple tank) "are noted for their ceremonial use" (PDF p. 105)	Ties the bull to ritual procession and ceremony , not merely to iconography

- ANALYSIS: **Mythology leg, bounded honestly.** The **vahana** is defined in this folder's sources as "the mount or vehicle of the main deity... placed just before the sanctum sanctorum" (*Nitin...pdf, PDF p. 72*), and Nandi is placed exactly there in every case above, facing a **Shiva** sanctum. FACT: That much is fully supported: **the bull is Shiva's mount and its architectural position encodes that relationship.** WRONG: **Do not** narrate a Nandi origin myth, a Puranic episode, a Vedic identification of the bull with Rudra, or a "Dharma has four legs / bull of dharma" reading - **no local source in this folder supplies any of them**, and this is the single most likely place to fabricate in this question. If the answer needs a mythological sentence, use the **Sarnath Taurus/birth** meaning and the **vahana** definition, both of which are sourced.

F. The lion in temple architecture - Yali and Vyala as composite forms

- FACT: **Yali** - a **composite lion figure** that "becomes symbolic of the **Nayaka architectural identity**," carved on gopurams and on the pillars of **Vijayanagara** temples; in **Tamil literature** it is a mythical creature with a **cat-like body, the head of a lion with the tusks of an elephant and the tail of a serpent**, described as **more powerful than the lion, the tiger or the elephant**, and understood as a **guardian creature protecting human beings both physically and spiritually** (*Nitin...pdf, PDF pp. 114, 118*). FACT: In the

South Indian sculpture chapter the Yali is given as "a mythological creature with the head and body of a lion and the trunk, tusks of an elephant" (PDF p. 209).

- ANALYSIS: **Two source formulations of the Yali's anatomy exist** (p. 118 "cat-like body... tail of a serpent"; p. 209 "head and body of a lion... trunk and tusks of an elephant"). FACT: Both are the same source; state the **composite, lion-based, elephant-tusked** core and do **not** present either variant as an error.

- FACT: **Vyala** - at **Khajuraho**, sculptures on temples dedicated to Vishnu include the **Vyalas**, "**hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies**," also found in other Indian temples (*Nitin...pdf*, PDF p. 81; basic/03 §13.4).

- FACT: **Friezes**: the Hoysala temples carry bands of ****elephants, lions, scrolls, horses, makaras and swans (PDF p. 105) - the lion inside a repeating ordered register****, i.e. as structure, not incident.

- ANALYSIS: **Analytical point**: in temple architecture the lion is rarely a naturalistic lion. It is **hybridised (Yali/Vyala) and multiplied (friezes, pillar bases)** and it does **guardian and load-bearing** duty. That is a genuine contrast with the Mauryan lion, which is **singular, naturalistic, elevated and inscribed**.

G. The 15-mark structure (executable end to end from this file)

Step	What to write	Named evidence
1. Thesis (2 lines)	ANALYSIS: "The lion and the bull are not two decorative animals but two <i>functions</i> : across Indian traditions the bull is repeatedly attached to birth, fertility, agrarian power and the deity's service , while the lion is attached to authority, doctrine and guardianship - which is why they can stand at the same site, in the same reign, and still do different work."	Rampurva
2. Mythology leg (short, bounded)	Bull as vahana placed before the Shiva sanctum; bull as Taurus/birth month ; lion as enlightenment ; Yali in Tamil literature as guardian	PDF pp. 43-44, 72, 118
3. Art leg - earliest	Harappan humped bull frequent, lion absent from seals; bronze bull of Kalibangan ; the undeciphered-script caution	PDF pp. 191, 193
4. Art leg - Buddhist	Aniconic bull = birth, lion = sermon ; Sarnath's four-lion capital and four-animal abacus; the Rampurva inscribed-lion / uninscribed-bull pair	PDF pp. 42-44, 233-234, 776
5. Architecture leg - bull	Nandi mandapa as a building on axis: Thanjavur (second largest monolith), Lepakshi (largest), Ellora Kailasa, Ramappa, Hoysala Nandi Pavilion with kalyani	PDF pp. 61, 91, 105, 107, 109, 329
6. Architecture leg - lion	Yali on Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka gopurams; Vyala at Khajuraho; lion friezes at Hoysala sites	PDF pp. 81, 105, 114, 118
7. Change over time	Lion: naturalistic and imperial (Mauryan) -> hybrid and protective (medieval Yali/Vyala). Bull: Harappan image without recoverable meaning -> Buddhist birth-symbol -> Shaiva vahana with dedicated architecture	Cross-file
8. Qualification	Symbol meanings are reconstructed from later texts and from context ; the Harappan corpus cannot be read through Puranic categories; and depiction records patron choice , not popular belief (§13.8)	-
9. Verdict	ANALYSIS: "The two animals endure because each solved a different representational problem - the bull made generative power visible and the lion made authority visible - and the survival of the Sarnath lions on the national emblem since 26 January 1950 shows the second problem is still being solved the same way."	PDF p. 43

ANALYSIS: **Factual cautions specific to this bank.** WRONG: Do not attribute the Sarnath capital's animals to any meaning other than the four the source gives. WRONG: Do not claim a lion appears on Harappan seals. WRONG: Do not supply a Nandi or bull myth, a Nandi name-etymology, or a Vedic bull identification from memory. WRONG: Do not date the Rampurva bull pillar independently of Ashoka. WRONG: Do not state Yali dimensions, counts of pillars, or a temple's Yali total. ANALYSIS: Sanchi's lion-capital pillar is dated "around 250 BC" by the source; keep the approximation.

13.6B Evidence bank C++ - Gandhara's Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements (the direct 2019 GS-I 10-mark route)

Direct Mains route, promoted to Core (final pass, 2026-08-13). CSE 2019 GS-I Q1 - "Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art" (10 marks · 150 words). The controlling ledger routed this to advanced/06 and to Ancient-Indian-History/advanced/16. **Core routing supersedes both pointers:** the demand is answerable here, from §13.5 plus the disaggregation below. The Ancient History Core file on Central Asian contacts remains a legitimate *support*, not a requirement.

ANALYSIS: What the directive "highlight" demands: named elements, each attributed to the *right* source of influence. The commonest failure is to answer "Greek influence" six times. The question names **two distinct external strands - Greco-Bactrian** (Hellenistic, transmitted through the Bactrian Greek kingdoms) and **Central Asian** (Kushana, Parthian, Saka) - and marks follow from telling them apart.

Strand	FACT: Element visible in the sculpture	FACT: Source basis	ANALYSIS: How to phrase it
Greco-Bactrian / Hellenistic	Wavy hair; slender musculature and anatomically modelled bodies; pleated, heavy drapery with realistic folds; composed stillness of expression; elongated earlobes treated naturalistically	<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 200-205, 299-301 (§13.5)	The surface treatment and the human body are Hellenised
Greco-Bactrian, in material	Bluish-grey sandstone , and stucco in the later phase	Same	Material choice belongs with the workshop tradition, not the subject
Central Asian - patronage	Kushana patronage; the school flourishes under a dynasty of Central Asian origin	Same; Ancient-Indian-History Core on Kushana contacts	Patronage is the <i>mechanism</i> by which the influence arrived - say so
Central Asian - layered influence	Influence explicitly described as "heavy Greek/Hellenistic, layered with Parthian and Central Asian/Bactrian elements "	§13.5, from PDF pp. 200-205	"Layered" is the exam word: successive, not simultaneous
Indian core that was not borrowed	The subject - a Buddhist iconographic programme; mudras (Gandhara Buddha commonly in Abhaya Mudra in the comparator school); the halo ; the monastic robe	§13.5	This is what turns a list into an argument
Diffusion outward	Gandhara transmitted into Central Asia and East Asia	§13.5	Influence ran both ways - a strong closing line

- ANALYSIS: **Thesis to use (from §13.2, unchanged):** "Gandhara is best described

as a **Buddhist iconographic programme executed in a Hellenised visual idiom under Kushana patronage** - the subject is Indian, the surface treatment is borrowed, and calling it 'Greek art' inverts the relationship."

- ANALYSIS: **Comparison that earns the extra mark in 150 words:** one clause on

Mathura - indigenous development, **spotted red sandstone**, Buddhist *and* Hindu *and* Jain scope - proves the Gandhara features are **not** simply "what Indian sculpture looked like then" (§13.5).

- **WRONG: Cautions:** do not name individual Greek or Bactrian rulers, artists, workshops or dates from memory; do not assert that Gandhara produced the **first** human Buddha image (priority is disputed - §13.6); do not reduce Gandhara to "Greek art"; do not attribute Amaravati's features to foreign influence, since the source states it "developed on purely indigenous lines with no foreign influence" (PDF p. 301).

13.6C The 2022 medieval-temple-sculpture demand - this file's half

Direct Mains route, promoted to Core (final pass, 2026-08-13). CSE 2022 GS-I Q1 - "Medieval Indian temple sculptures represent the social life of those days. How will you explain this statement?" (10 marks · 150 words). The controlling ledger pointed this at advanced/06; **Core routing supersedes it**. Joint ownership: basic/03 §13.10 holds the register-by-register social-evidence bank (performance, instruction, court and everyday life, devotional movement, gender and patronage, with what each can and cannot evidence); **this file** supplies the reading method and the source-criticism that the directive "how will you explain" actually rewards.

- **FACT: Method:** run §13.4's six variables - material, posture/gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context, cross-site comparison - on the sculpted register, then convert each into a social claim.
- **FACT: Named evidence available here:** the Khajuraho programme's dancers, musicians, teachers and disciples, and its **Vyalas** (PDF p. 81); **Shalabhanjika** as a fertility/auspiciousness motif carried across Hindu, Buddhist and Jain art for a millennium (PDF pp. 198-199); **Kalyanasundara Murti** (9th century AD) rendering *panigrahana*, the marriage ceremony, through two statuettes - Shiva accepting Parvati's right hand as she steps forward with a bashful expression (PDF p. 212) - the single best "sculpture depicts a **social ritual**" case in Core; **Saptamatrikas** and **Kirtimukha** as South Indian programme elements (PDF pp. 208-209).
- **ANALYSIS: The explanation the directive wants:** sculpture is *commissioned representation*. It is strong evidence of **what patrons chose to make visible** and of the **techniques and materials available**; it is weak evidence of belief, behaviour or the condition of ordinary people. Say this **inside** the answer rather than treating carvings as photographs (§13.8).
- **WRONG:** Do not use Khajuraho's erotic sculpture as a demographic or moral claim about medieval society; do not generalise from royal temples to village life.

Object/class	FACT: Evidence	Analytical use	Caution
Cire-perdue bronze	FACT: Lost-wax casting known since the Indus period: wax figure clay-coated, heated to melt out the wax, filled with molten metal (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 190, 195)	The single technical thread running from the Dancing Girl to Chola bronzes	ANALYSIS: Continuity of technique is not continuity of style or meaning
Harappan figures	FACT: So-called Pashupati seal (steatite, Mohenjo-daro); Dancing Girl; terracotta female figures; Bearded Priest (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 191-193)	Shows sophistication alongside crudity in the same corpus	WRONG: "Mother Goddess," "Priest-King" and "Pashupati" are modern labels; the script is undeciphered
Yaksha/Yakshi	FACT: Folk deities of water, fertility, trees and wilderness, absorbed into Vedic, Buddhist, Jain and Hindu worship; Didarganj chauri-bearer and Parkham Yaksha with Mauryan polish (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 197-198)	Popular cult entering monumental sculpture - the best evidence against a purely court-driven art history	ANALYSIS: Didarganj's Mauryan date is debated
Shalabhanjika	FACT: Yakshi-holding-a-tree motif, a bracket figure at Sanchi and Bharhut, later in Hoysala temples; fertility/auspiciousness (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 198-199)	A motif traceable across a millennium and three religions	-
Pottery sequence	FACT: Neolithic hand-made coarse ware -> Chalcolithic painted ware (Ahar, Malwa, Jorwe) -> Harappan Red Ware -> Painted Grey Ware -> NBPW (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 194, 199)	Datable material-culture spine for any "sources" question	WRONG: Harappan pottery is mostly red ware with black painting, not the separate Black-and-Red Ware category
Gupta sculpture	FACT: Sarnath school, cream-coloured sandstone and metal, subtly modelled thinly draped figures; the c. 7th-century Sultanganj copper Buddha safer described as late/post-Gupta	The restraint contrast against both Gandhara drama and later Chandella density	ANALYSIS: Do not date Sultanganj firmly to the Gupta period
South Indian temple sculpture	FACT: Kirtimukha (monster-face motif, also in Buddhist architecture), musical pillars, Saptamatrikas (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF p. 208); Kalyanasundara Murti (9th century AD) representing <i>panigrahana</i> , the marriage ceremony, through two separate statuettes - Shiva accepting Parvati's right hand as she steps forward with a bashful expression (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF p. 212)	Named, describable cases for a South Indian sculpture demand	-

13.7A Evidence bank D+ - terracotta as a continuous Indian tradition

Why this exists. A hostile review found that terracotta appeared in this folder only as scattered rows - a Harappan figurine here, a Gupta plaque there - with **no continuity argument**, although "terracotta tradition from Harappa to the present" is a standard 10/15-mark demand and a recurring objective pairing.

Phase	FACT: Named evidence (Nitin...pdf)	Material / technique	Function
Harappan	Terracotta female figures among the Mohenjo-daro/Harappan corpus; terracotta models of ploughs at Bahawalpur and Banawali ; terracotta seals alongside steatite, agate, chert, copper and faience (PDF pp. 37, 190, 193)	FACT: Fire-baked clay ; the figures were made using the pinching method; the source itself records that terracotta sculptures were " less in number and crude in shape and form " compared with the bronzes (PDF p. 193)	Domestic/ritual images, and - in the plough models - a technological record
Early historic	Chandraketugarh (near the Bidyadhari river, North 24 Parganas, West Bengal), "filled with amazing terracotta sculpture," with NBPW relics and Maurya/Kushana/Gupta-period sculpture; its terracotta art "exhibits an amazing degree of precision and craftsmanship" (PDF p. 38). ANALYSIS: The routed CSE 2021 pairing Chandraketugarh : terracotta art is reproduced in the source (PDF p. 167)	Moulded and modelled fired clay	Urban craft production, and a datable site marker
Gupta	Terracotta figures classified as (i) gods and goddesses and (ii) male and female figures ; Buddha figures and ornaments at Devnimori (Gujarat) ; a large collection of plaques at Bikaner and Ahichchhatra ; distinctive heads from Akhnur (Kashmir) ; numerous objects from Bhita (PDF p. 208)	Plaque and figure moulding	FACT: The phase where terracotta carries a full religious programme , not only folk imagery
Regional architecture	The Bengal school used burnt bricks and clay , " known as terracotta bricks ," as the principal building material (PDF p. 121)	Structural brick with moulded relief	FACT: The decisive continuity case: terracotta moves from object to building material and façade programme (basic/03, basic/04)
Living craft	ANALYSIS: Bounded . See the caution below	-	-

- ANALYSIS: **Analytical spine (the argument, not the list)**: terracotta is the only Indian medium that is simultaneously **the cheapest, the most widely distributed, the least durable in the open and the most continuously practised**. That combination is why it survives best where it was *fired and buried* (seals, plaques, figurines) or *built into a wall* (Bengal), and why its social range - domestic shrine to royal temple façade - is wider than that of stone or bronze.

- ANALYSIS: **Community and continuity, honestly bounded**. WRONG: **No local source in this folder names Bankura horses, Molela plaques, or any specific present-day potter community as a terracotta tradition. **Do not supply them as facts**. FACT: What is supported for continuity is: the **cire-perdue metal technique "even today... practised in many parts of the country"** (PDF p. 193) as the **parallel case of an unbroken technique**; Gundiya and Lodai in Kutch, Gujarat, recorded as "**famous pottery making villages**" (PDF p. 196) - **pottery, not figurative terracotta, and the distinction must be kept**; and the Bengal terracotta-brick **building tradition**. ANALYSIS: If a question demands living terracotta centres by name, write the mechanism** (hereditary artisan communities, local clay, festival and shrine demand, GI-type protection routed through basic/12) and say plainly that named centres are outside this folder's verified evidence, rather than inventing them.

- WRONG: Do not date Chandraketugarh, do not assign it to a named dynasty beyond the periods listed, and do not state figurine dimensions, firing temperatures or counts.

- **School comparison**: "The three post-Mauryan schools are best distinguished not by quality but by problem: Gandhara solved how to give the Buddha a body, Mathura how to give Indian deities a shared visual grammar, and Amaravati how to tell a story on a curved stone surface."

- **Iconography**: "Indian iconography is legible because it is systematic:

each attribute carries an assigned meaning, so identification and interpretation are the same operation performed carefully."

- **Sculpture as evidence:** "Sculpture is reliable evidence of what

patrons wanted made visible and of the technical means available to make it; it is unreliable evidence of everyday belief and behaviour, and the distinction should be stated rather than assumed."

13.9 Factual-risk and dynamic-status controls

- WRONG: Do not state that Chola patronage originated Nataraja iconography.
- WRONG: Do not date the Didarganj Yakshi firmly to the Mauryan period.
- WRONG: Do not treat "Pashupati," "Mother Goddess" or "Priest-King" as

deciphered identities.

- WRONG: Do not reduce Gandhara to "Greek art."
- WRONG: **Lion/bull bank (§13.6A):** do not place a **lion** on any Harappan

seal; do not narrate a Nandi, Rudra-bull or "bull of dharma" myth from memory; do not add meanings to the Sarnath abacus animals beyond the four the source assigns; do not date the Rampurva bull pillar apart from Ashoka; do not present either of the source's two Yali anatomies as an error.

- WRONG: **Terracotta bank (§13.7A):** do not name a living terracotta centre, community or product (Bankura, Molela or any other) as verified - the folder's sources do not carry them.

- WRONG: Do not invent sculpture heights, weights, alloy compositions or museum accession details.

- ANALYSIS: Any claim about a sculpture's **current** location, display or conservation status - including the Amaravati marbles held abroad - needs a dated official source; repatriation claims are governed by topic 14's rule requiring object, institution, provenance and date.

2026 PYQ Integration

Status: 2026 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026 .md. **Answer-key rule:** The 2026 Prelims and CSAT Set-A keys held locally are **provisional**; no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Year represented:** 2026
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2026	Prelims GS-I	12	Empty seat symbolism in early Buddhist visual and sacred iconography	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans-2026-GS1-Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- Empty seat symbolism in early Buddhist visual and sacred iconography

This block integrates the 2026 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 and 2024-2025 blocks and does not convert a provisionally-keyed, answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - VERIFIED PYQS AND FINAL ANSWER SPINE

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Verified PYQs and final answer spine

|
v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · Verified PYQs · final answer spine · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Subject

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: 196) - pottery, not figurative terracotta, and the distinction must be kept; and the Bengal terracotta-brick building tradition. ANALYSIS: If a question demands living terracotta centres by name, write the mechanism (hereditary artisan communities, local clay, festival and shrine demand, GI-type protection routed through basic/12) and say plainly that named centres are outside this folder's verified evidence, rather than inventing them. WRONG: Do not date Chandraketugarh, do not assign it to a named dynasty beyond the periods listed, and do not state figurine dimensions, firing temperatures or counts.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: WRONG: Do not state that Chola patronage originated Nataraja iconography. WRONG: Do not date the Didarganj Yakshi firmly to the Mauryan period. WRONG: Do not treat "Pashupati," "Mother Goddess" or "Priest-King" as deciphered identities. WRONG: Do not reduce Gandhara to "Greek art." WRONG: Lion/bull bank (§13.6A): do not place a lion on any Harappan seal; do not narrate a Nandi, Rudra-bull or "bull of dharma" myth from memory; do not add meanings to the Sarnath abacus animals beyond the four the source assigns; do not date the Rampurva bull pillar apart from Ashoka; do not present either of the source's two Yali anatomies as an error. WRONG: Terracotta bank (§13.7A): do not name a living terracotta centre, community or product (Bankura, Molela or any other) as verified - the folder's sources do not carry them. WRONG: Do not invent sculpture heights, weights, alloy compositions or museum accession details. ANALYSIS: Any claim about a sculpture's current location, display or conservation status - including the Amaravati marbles held abroad - needs a dated official source; repatriation claims are governed by topic 14's rule requiring object, institution, provenance and date.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: 197-198). FACT: Gandhara and Mathura both participated, around the early centuries CE, in the shift toward anthropomorphic Buddha images; priority between them is debated, so "Gandhara first" should not be stated as settled.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: ANALYSIS: Analytical spine (the argument, not the list): terracotta is the only Indian medium that is simultaneously the cheapest, the most widely distributed, the least durable in the open and the most continuously practised.

INDIAN ART AND CULTURE DEEP-REVIEW CORE CONTROL

- **Must remember:** Sculpture and pottery must be read through material, technique, posture, attribute, patron and site, from lost-wax casting and pottery sequences to Gandhara, Mathura, Amaravati, Gupta and Chola visual programmes.
- **Close distinction:** Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati differ by material, religious scope and visual grammar; symbolic Buddha representation preceded broadly overlapping Gandhara-Mathura iconic production, so sole-origin claims are unsafe.
- **Evidence / interpretation limit:** Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern Harappan labels; Chola bronzes canonised rather than originated Nataraja, and temple sculpture records patron-selected visibility rather than a social census.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which statement correctly identifies Six-variable sculpture method?

A. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. B. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. C. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. D. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware.

Answer: A. Explanation: Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. The

remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q2. Which chronology card should be filed under Six-variable sculpture method?

A. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. B. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. C. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. D. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script.

Answer: B. Explanation: Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Six-variable sculpture method?

A. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. B. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. C. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. D. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.

Answer: C. Explanation: Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Six-variable sculpture method?

A. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. B. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. C. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. D. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

Answer: D. Explanation: Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q5. Which statement correctly identifies Cire-perdue technique?

A. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. B. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. C. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. D. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware.

Answer: A. Explanation: In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q6. Which chronology card should be filed under Cire-perdue technique?

A. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. B. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. C. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. D. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware.

Answer: B. Explanation: In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Cire-perdue technique?

A. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. B. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. C. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. D. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.

Answer: C. Explanation: In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Cire-perdue technique?

A. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. B. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. C. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. D. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.

Answer: D. Explanation: In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q9. Which statement correctly identifies Harappan label caution?

A. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. B. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. C. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. D. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.

Answer: A. Explanation: Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q10. Which chronology card should be filed under Harappan label caution?

A. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. B. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. C. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. D. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware.

Answer: B. Explanation: Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Harappan label caution?

A. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. B. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. C. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. D. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

Answer: C. Explanation: Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Harappan label caution?

A. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. B. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. C. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. D. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script.

Answer: D. Explanation: Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q13. Which statement correctly identifies Pottery sequence?

A. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. B. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. C. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. D. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.

Answer: A. Explanation: The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q14. Which chronology card should be filed under Pottery sequence?

A. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. B. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. C. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. D. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

Answer: B. Explanation: The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Pottery sequence?

A. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. B. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. C. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. D. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting.

Answer: C. Explanation: The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Pottery sequence?

A. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. B. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. C. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. D. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware.

Answer: D. Explanation: The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q17. Which statement correctly identifies Northern Black Polished Ware?

A. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. B. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. C. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. D. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.

Answer: A. Explanation: NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q18. Which chronology card should be filed under Northern Black Polished Ware?

A. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. B. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. C. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. D. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.

Answer: B. Explanation: NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Northern Black Polished Ware?

A. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. B. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. C. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. D. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure.

Answer: C. Explanation: NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Northern Black Polished Ware?

A. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. B. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. C. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. D. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware.

Answer: D. Explanation: NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q21. Which statement correctly identifies Yaksha, Yakshi and Shalabhanjika?

A. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. B. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. C. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. D. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

Answer: A. Explanation: Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q22. Which chronology card should be filed under Yaksha, Yakshi and Shalabhanjika?

A. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. B. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. C. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. D. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

Answer: B. Explanation: Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Yaksha, Yakshi and Shalabhanjika?

A. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. B. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. C. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. D. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting.

Answer: C. Explanation: Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Yaksha, Yakshi and Shalabhanjika?

A. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. B. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. C. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. D. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.

Answer: D. Explanation: Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q25. Which statement correctly identifies Gandhara school?

A. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. B. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. C. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. D. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

Answer: A. Explanation: Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q26. Which chronology card should be filed under Gandhara school?

A. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. B. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. C. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. D. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting.

Answer: B. Explanation: Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Gandhara school?

A. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. B. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. C. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. D. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin.

Answer: C. Explanation: Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Gandhara school?

A. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. B. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. C. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. D. Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.

Answer: D. Explanation: Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q29. Which statement correctly identifies Mathura school?

A. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. B. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. C. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. D. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting.

Answer: A. Explanation: Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q30. Which chronology card should be filed under Mathura school?

A. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. B. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. C. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. D. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin.

Answer: B. Explanation: Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Mathura school?

A. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. B. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. C. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. D. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it.

Answer: C. Explanation: Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Mathura school?

A. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. B. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. C. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. D. Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.

Answer: D. Explanation: Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q33. Which statement correctly identifies Amaravati school?

A. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. B. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. C. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. D. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin.

Answer: A. Explanation: Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q34. Which chronology card should be filed under Amaravati school?

A. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. B. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. C. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. D. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta.

Answer: B. Explanation: Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Amaravati school?

A. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. B. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. C. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. D. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

Answer: C. Explanation: Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Amaravati school?

A. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. B. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. C. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. D. Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting.

Answer: D. Explanation: Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q37. Which statement correctly identifies Aniconic symbolism?

A. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. B. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. C. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. D. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it.

Answer: A. Explanation: Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q38. Which chronology card should be filed under Aniconic symbolism?

A. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. B. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. C. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. D. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

Answer: B. Explanation: Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Aniconic symbolism?

A. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. B. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. C. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. D. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

Answer: C. Explanation: Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Aniconic symbolism?

A. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. B. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. C. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. D. Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure.

Answer: D. Explanation: Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q41. Which statement correctly identifies Parallel iconic shift?

A. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. B. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. C. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. D. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

Answer: A. Explanation: Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q42. Which chronology card should be filed under Parallel iconic shift?

A. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. B. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. C. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. D. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system.

Answer: B. Explanation: Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Parallel iconic shift?

A. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. B. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. C. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. D. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

Answer: C. Explanation: Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Parallel iconic shift?

A. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyālas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. B. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. C. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. D. Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin.

Answer: D. Explanation: Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q45. Which statement correctly identifies Gupta Sarnath idiom?

A. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. B. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. C. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. D. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q46. Which chronology card should be filed under Gupta Sarnath idiom?

A. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. B. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. C. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. D. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Gupta Sarnath idiom?

A. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. B. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. C. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. D. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Gupta Sarnath idiom?

A. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. B. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. C. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. D. The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q49. Which statement correctly identifies Nataraja origin and peak?

A. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. B. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. C. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. D. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

Answer: A. Explanation: The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q50. Which chronology card should be filed under Nataraja origin and peak?

A. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. B. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. C. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. D. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies.

Answer: B. Explanation: The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Nataraja origin and peak?

A. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. B. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. C. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. D. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

Answer: C. Explanation: The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Nataraja origin and peak?

A. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. B. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. C. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. D. The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it.

Answer: D. Explanation: The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q53. Which statement correctly identifies Nataraja attribute system?

A. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. B. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. C. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. D. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

Answer: A. Explanation: Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q54. Which chronology card should be filed under Nataraja attribute system?

A. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. B. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. C. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. D. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

Answer: B. Explanation: Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Nataraja attribute system?

A. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. B. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. C. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. D. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

Answer: C. Explanation: Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Nataraja attribute system?

A. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. B. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. C. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. D. Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

Answer: D. Explanation: Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q57. Which statement correctly identifies Lion and bull programme?

A. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. B. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. C. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. D. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

Answer: A. Explanation: Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q58. Which chronology card should be filed under Lion and bull programme?

A. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. B. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. C. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. D. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

Answer: B. Explanation: Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Lion and bull programme?

A. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. B. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. C. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. D. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

Answer: C. Explanation: Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Lion and bull programme?

A. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. B. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. C. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. D. Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system.

Answer: D. Explanation: Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q61. Which statement correctly identifies Nandi as architecture?

A. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. B. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. C. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. D. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

Answer: A. Explanation: At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q62. Which chronology card should be filed under Nandi as architecture?

A. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. B. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. C. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. D. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades.

Answer: B. Explanation: At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Nandi as architecture?

A. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. B. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. C. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. D. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

Answer: C. Explanation: At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Nandi as architecture?

A. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. B. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. C. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. D. At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.

Answer: D. Explanation: At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q65. Which statement correctly identifies Yali and Vyala distinction?

A. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. B. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. C. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. D. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades.

Answer: A. Explanation: Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q66. Which chronology card should be filed under Yali and Vyala distinction?

A. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. B. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. C. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. D. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

Answer: B. Explanation: Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Yali and Vyala distinction?

A. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. B. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. C. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. D. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

Answer: C. Explanation: Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Yali and Vyala distinction?

A. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. B. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. C. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. D. Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies.

Answer: D. Explanation: Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q69. Which statement correctly identifies Temple sculpture as social evidence?

A. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. B. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. C. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. D. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades.

Answer: A. Explanation: Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q70. Which chronology card should be filed under Temple sculpture as social evidence?

A. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. B. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. C. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. D. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.

Answer: B. Explanation: Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Temple sculpture as social evidence?

A. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. B. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. C. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. D. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script.

Answer: C. Explanation: Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Temple sculpture as social evidence?

A. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. B. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. C. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. D. Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

Answer: D. Explanation: Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q73. Which statement correctly identifies Terracotta continuity?

A. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketurah craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. B. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. C. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. D. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.

Answer: A. Explanation: Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketurah craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q74. Which chronology card should be filed under Terracotta continuity?

A. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. B. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. C. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. D. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.

Answer: B. Explanation: Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Terracotta continuity?

A. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. B. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. C. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. D. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.

Answer: C. Explanation: Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Terracotta continuity?

A. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. B. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. C. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. D. Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades.

Answer: D. Explanation: Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandraketugarh craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Verified sculpture PYQ routes?

A. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. B. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. C. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. D. Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.

Answer: A. Explanation: The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”, every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the cultural demand in “Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Verified sculpture PYQ routes?
Analysis: Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** A. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** B. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** C. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the cultural demand in “Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise five named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For “Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

Q78. Which chronology card should be filed under Verified sculpture PYQ routes?

A. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. B. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. C. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. D. In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.

Answer: B. Explanation: The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Q78. Which chronology card should be filed under Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”, every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the cultural demand in “Q78. Which chronology card should be filed under Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Q78. Which chronology card should be filed under Verified sculpture PYQ routes?
Analysis: Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** A. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** B. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** C. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the cultural demand in “Q78. Which chronology card should be filed under Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise five named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For “Q78. Which chronology card should be filed under Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Verified sculpture PYQ routes?

A. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. B. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. C. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. D. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware.

Answer: C. Explanation: The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Demand decoding: Treat “Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Verified sculpture PYQ routes?” as a form, chronology, region, patron, medium and status problem. Verify every pairing independently without inventing an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the cultural demand in “Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Verified sculpture PYQ routes? **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

2. **Claim and named evidence:** A. Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** B. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** C. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the cultural demand in “Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Fix the category and period; pair form with region, material, patron or institution; separate historical fact from later label or current recognition; eliminate the closest distractor.

Why this earns marks: It preserves answer-text integrity and exact category mapping while keeping reasoned elimination separate from an official key.

How to improve this answer: For “Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”, state why the nearest distractor fails on medium, region, chronology, patronage, terminology or recognition status.

Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Verified sculpture PYQ routes?

A. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. B. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. C. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. D. The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance.

Answer: D. Explanation: The routed direct Mains cluster comprises 2019 Gandhara external elements and the 2022 demands on medieval temple sculpture as social evidence and lion-bull significance. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Demand decoding: Treat “Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Verified sculpture PYQ routes?” as a form, chronology, region, patron, medium and status problem. Verify every pairing independently without inventing an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the cultural demand in “Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Verified sculpture PYQ routes?”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Verified sculpture PYQ routes? **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** A. NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. **Analysis:**

Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** B. Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** C. The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the cultural demand in "Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Verified sculpture PYQ routes?".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Fix the category and period; pair form with region, material, patron or institution; separate historical fact from later label or current recognition; eliminate the closest distractor.

Why this earns marks: It preserves answer-text integrity and exact category mapping while keeping reasoned elimination separate from an official key.

How to improve this answer: For "Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Verified sculpture PYQ routes?", state why the nearest distractor fails on medium, region, chronology, patronage, terminology or recognition status.

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

Three direct GS-I Mains demands are verified in the 2018-2023 routing ledger: 2019 Gandhara external elements, 2022 medieval temple sculpture as social evidence, and 2022 lion-bull significance. The 2026 empty-seat objective route has only a provisional key and is retained unsolved.

OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

7. Exact PYQ application

FACT: 2025 Q3 (Chandella sculpture), supported by this topic: while Topic 03 owns the direct answer, this topic supplies the **iconographic reading method** - reading posture, gesture, material and comparative motif (as applied to Nataraja above) - that a strong answer on "resilient vigour and breadth of life" in Chandella sculpture should also apply to Khajuraho's figural corpus. **ANALYSIS:** No Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers tests sculpture/pottery/iconography as a stand-alone topic.

2026 PYQ Integration

Status: 2026 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026.md. **Answer-key rule:** The 2026 Prelims and CSAT Set-A keys held locally are **provisional**; no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Year represented:** 2026
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2026	Prelims GS-I	12	Empty seat symbolism in early Buddhist visual and sacred iconography	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - 2026 - GS1 - Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- Empty seat symbolism in early Buddhist visual and sacred iconography

This block integrates the 2026 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 and 2024-2025 blocks and does not convert a provisionally-keyed, answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

8. Exact PYQ application

FACT: 2025 Q3 (Chandella sculpture), advanced support: apply the six-factor method (Section 4) to structure a topic-03 answer with explicit evidentiary categories rather than adjective-heavy description. **ANALYSIS:** No Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers tests sculpture/ pottery/iconography as a stand-alone topic; this file's contribution is entirely in strengthening topic 03's and topic 09's answers.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2019, 2022
- **Paper(s):** GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 3

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2019	GS-I	1	Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art	Highlight · 10 marks · 150 words	Cross-cutting; art form and Kushana contact both linked	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-I	1	Medieval Indian temple sculptures as evidence of social life	How will you explain · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-I	13	Lion and bull figures in Indian mythology art and architecture	Discuss the significance · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art
- Medieval Indian temple sculptures as evidence of social life
- Lion and bull figures in Indian mythology art and architecture

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 GS-I

Demand: Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art. (Answer in 150 words)

Status: Verified routed direct Mains demand.

Model solution: Separate Greco-Bactrian body modelling, wavy hair, pleated drapery and workshop material from Central Asian Kushana patronage and layered Parthian-Bactrian transmission; retain the Buddhist subject and add one Mathura contrast.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 GS-I”, every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Separate Greco-Bactrian body modelling, wavy hair, pleated drapery and workshop material from Central Asian Kushana patronage and layered Parthian-Bactrian transmission; retain the Buddhist subject and add one Mathura contrast.

Qualification: Bound the claim by period, region, medium, patronage and evidence status; do not convert similarity into direct descent or a commissioned representation into a social census.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise five named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 GS-I", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2022 GS-I

Demand: Medieval Indian temple sculptures represent the social life of those days. How will you explain this statement? (Answer in 150 words)

Status: Verified routed direct Mains demand.

Model solution: Use dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes as patron-selected registers; apply material, posture and site context; qualify that commissioned temple images are not demographic photographs.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2022 GS-I", every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Use dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes as patron-selected registers; apply material, posture and site context; qualify that commissioned temple images are not demographic photographs.

Qualification: Bound the claim by period, region, medium, patronage and evidence status; do not convert similarity into direct descent or a commissioned representation into a social census.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise five named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2022 GS-I", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2022 GS-I

Demand: Discuss the significance of the lion and bull figures in Indian mythology, art and architecture. (Answer in 250 words)

Status: Verified routed direct Mains demand.

Model solution: Keep mythology, art and architecture as separate legs; use Harappan bull caution, Rampurva and Sarnath, Nandi mandapas and Yali-Vyala programmes; close with the national-emblem continuity without inventing meanings.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2022 GS-I", every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Keep mythology, art and architecture as separate legs; use Harappan bull caution, Rampurva and Sarnath, Nandi mandapas and Yali-Vyala programmes; close with the national-emblem continuity without inventing meanings.

Qualification: Bound the claim by period, region, medium, patronage and evidence status; do not convert similarity into direct descent or a commissioned representation into a social census.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise five named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For “PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2022 GS-I”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: Gandhara was a Buddhist iconographic programme rendered in a Hellenised surface idiom under Kushana patronage; named external elements must be separated from the Indian subject.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.
- Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.
- Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin.

Qualified conclusion: Gandhara was a Buddhist iconographic programme rendered in a Hellenised surface idiom under Kushana patronage; named external elements must be separated from the Indian subject.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art. Answer in about 150...”, every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Gandhara was a Buddhist iconographic programme rendered in a Hellenised surface idiom under Kushana patronage; named external elements must be separated from the Indian subject.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: Gandhara was a Buddhist iconographic programme rendered in a Hellenised surface idiom under Kushana patronage; named external elements must be separated from the Indian subject.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise three named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For “Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art. Answer in about 150...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: How can medieval temple sculpture be used as evidence of social life? Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: Temple sculpture records patron-selected social and ritual visibility through named registers, but cannot be treated as a representative census of ordinary life.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis.
- Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society.

Qualified conclusion: Temple sculpture records patron-selected social and ritual visibility through named registers, but cannot be treated as a representative census of ordinary life.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “How can medieval temple sculpture be used as evidence of social life? Answer in about 150...”, every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Temple sculpture records patron-selected social and ritual visibility through named registers, but cannot be treated as a representative census of ordinary life.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Read sculpture through material, posture or gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context and cross-site comparison; this converts visual description into bounded historical analysis. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Dancers, musicians, teachers, couples and ritual scenes show what patrons selected for visibility; carvings are commissioned representations, not statistical photographs of medieval society. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: Temple sculpture records patron-selected social and ritual visibility through named registers, but cannot be treated as a representative census of ordinary life.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise three named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For “How can medieval temple sculpture be used as evidence of social life? Answer in about 150...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Compare the Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati schools on common axes. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Material, religious scope, external influence, posture, narrative treatment and patronage reveal three different workshop solutions rather than a quality hierarchy.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers.
- Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar.
- Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting.
- Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin.

Qualified conclusion: Material, religious scope, external influence, posture, narrative treatment and patronage reveal three different workshop solutions rather than a quality hierarchy.

Demand decoding: The directive **compare** requires a direct position on “Compare the Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati schools on common axes. Answer in about 250 words.”, every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Material, religious scope, external influence, posture, narrative treatment and patronage reveal three different workshop solutions rather than a quality hierarchy.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Gandhara sculpture used bluish-grey sandstone and later stucco for a mainly Buddhist programme whose drapery, hair and body modelling show Hellenistic, Parthian and Central Asian layers. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Mathura developed in spotted red sandstone, served Buddhist, Hindu and Jain patrons, and used attributes or avayudhas and emphatic halos within an indigenous visual grammar. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Amaravati or Vengi sculpture used dynamic narrative relief, greenish-white limestone and extensive tribhanga within a mainly Buddhist Satavahana and later Ikshvaku setting. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerged in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts at Gandhara and Mathura, so neither school should be declared the uncontested sole origin. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: Material, religious scope, external influence, posture, narrative treatment and patronage reveal three different workshop solutions rather than a quality hierarchy.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise five named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim

-> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For “Compare the Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati schools on common axes. Answer in about 250 words.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Explain the development and iconographic structure of Nataraja. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Nataraja must be traced from an early Chalukya antecedent to the Chola canonical bronze and decoded attribute by attribute through casting, gesture and ritual mobility.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.
- The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it.
- Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position.

Qualified conclusion: Nataraja must be traced from an early Chalukya antecedent to the Chola canonical bronze and decoded attribute by attribute through casting, gesture and ritual mobility.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on “Explain the development and iconographic structure of Nataraja. Answer in about 250 words.”, every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Nataraja must be traced from an early Chalukya antecedent to the Chola canonical bronze and decoded attribute by attribute through casting, gesture and ritual mobility.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The earliest known Nataraja example in the owner is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole, under early Chalukya rule; Chola bronzes perfected and ritualised the form rather than originating it. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Damaru signifies creation, fire destruction, abhaya reassurance, the raised foot release, Apasmara ignorance and the surrounding aureole cyclical time; each attribute must be read in position. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: Nataraja must be traced from an early Chalukya antecedent to the Chola canonical bronze and decoded attribute by attribute through casting, gesture and ritual mobility.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise five named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For “Explain the development and iconographic structure of Nataraja. Answer in about 250 words.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Discuss the significance of lion and bull figures in Indian mythology, art and architecture. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: The lion repeatedly visualised authority and doctrine while the bull marked generative, biographical and Shaiva-vahana meanings; Harappan, Buddhist and temple evidence must remain source-separated.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script.
- Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure.
- Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system.
- At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa.
- Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies.

Qualified conclusion: The lion repeatedly visualised authority and doctrine while the bull marked generative, biographical and Shaiva-vahana meanings; Harappan, Buddhist and temple evidence must remain source-separated.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Discuss the significance of lion and bull figures in Indian mythology, art and architecture....”, every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The lion repeatedly visualised authority and doctrine while the bull marked generative, biographical and Shaiva-vahana meanings; Harappan, Buddhist and temple evidence must remain source-separated.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern interpretive labels for Harappan objects, not identities read from the undeciphered script. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Early Buddhist programmes marked the Buddha through symbols such as the empty throne, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints and stupa; an empty seat is a presence-marker, not a missing figure. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Rampurva preserves an inscribed Ashokan lion pillar and an uninscribed bull pillar, while the Sarnath abacus places lion and bull within a wider Buddhist and imperial symbol system. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** At Shaiva temples the bull is not merely ornament: a Nandi mandapa or pavilion stands axially before the sanctum, as at Brihadishvara, Ellora Kailasa and Ramappa. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

5. **Claim and named evidence:** Yali is a composite lion-based guardian associated especially with Vijayanagara pillars and Nayaka identity, while Khajuraho Vyalas are hybrid imaginary animals with lions' bodies. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: The lion repeatedly visualised authority and doctrine while the bull marked generative, biographical and Shaiva-vahana meanings; Harappan, Buddhist and temple evidence must remain source-separated.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise six to eight named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For "Discuss the significance of lion and bull figures in Indian mythology, art and architecture....", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Trace the relationship between material, technique and meaning in Indian sculpture and pottery. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Clay, stone, stucco and bronze enabled different scales, movements and survival patterns; technique shaped representation while chronology and attribution limits prevent a simple progress story.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes.
- The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware.
- NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware.
- Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure.
- The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta.
- Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandrakertughar craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades.

Qualified conclusion: Clay, stone, stucco and bronze enabled different scales, movements and survival patterns; technique shaped representation while chronology and attribution limits prevent a simple progress story.

Demand decoding: The directive **trace** requires a direct position on "Trace the relationship between material, technique and meaning in Indian sculpture and...", every clause and time boundary, common-axis organisation, named evidence, a counter-position and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Clay, stone, stucco and bronze enabled different scales, movements and survival patterns; technique shaped representation while chronology and attribution limits prevent a simple progress story.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** In lost-wax casting a wax model is clay-coated, heated so the wax drains away, and filled with molten metal; the technique is evidenced from the Indus tradition and later enabled free-standing bronzes. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

2. **Claim and named evidence:** The source spine runs from Neolithic hand-made coarse ware through Chalcolithic painted wares, Harappan Red Ware and Painted Grey Ware to Northern Black Polished Ware. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** NBPW is fine lustrous tableware associated especially with early historic urbanisation; it is not exclusively a Mauryan court product and is not the same as Black-and-Red Ware. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Yaksha and Yakshi figures connect water, fertility, trees and wilderness with multiple religions; the Shalabhanjika is a tree-holding yakshi used as an auspicious bracket figure. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** The Sarnath school used cream-coloured sandstone and metal for subtly modelled, thinly draped figures; the Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.
6. **Claim and named evidence:** Terracotta moves from Harappan figurines and plough models to Chandrakertughar craft, Gupta plaques and Bengal architectural relief, linking domestic objects, urban workshops and façades. **Analysis:** Link form, medium, technique, patronage or performance context to the directive instead of merely listing the example. **Qualification:** State its chronological, regional, attributional or status boundary.

Counter-position / limit: A shared motif, material, religious setting or institutional label does not by itself establish identical function, direct descent, homogeneous community meaning or complete safeguarding.

Qualified conclusion: Clay, stone, stucco and bronze enabled different scales, movements and survival patterns; technique shaped representation while chronology and attribution limits prevent a simple progress story.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence definition and thesis; organise six to eight named monuments, objects, forms, texts, practitioners, communities or institutions as claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded close.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, compares like with like, connects form and patronage to social meaning, and avoids list-making, essentialism, false continuity and unsupported attribution.

How to improve this answer: For "Trace the relationship between material, technique and meaning in Indian sculpture and...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named monument, object, text, technique, community or official record and state what that evidence cannot prove.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Subject: Indian Art & Culture | **Tier:** Advanced | **GS Paper:** GS-I. **Core area:** Visual-reading method (material + posture + icon + patron + site + comparison); aniconism-to-iconism as an interpretive argument; Nataraja and Chandella sculpture as comparative case studies. **Grounded in:** Nitin Singhania, *Indian Art and Culture*, PDF pp. 189-214; R.S. Sharma, *India's Ancient Past*, PDF pp. 211-223, 347-355; 00_Master-Framework.md Sections 4-5; audited UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper I (supports Topic 03). **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = inference/analysis | **CURRENT:** = current anchor | **WRONG:** = trap. **Companion:** basic/06_Sculpture-Pottery-and-Iconography.md.

1. Analytical question and thesis

Question: What is the correct method for reading Indian sculpture as historical evidence, and how does that method sharpen an answer on Chandella sculpture's "resilient vigour and breadth of life"? **Thesis:** ANALYSIS: Indian sculpture should be read through a six-factor method - material, posture/gesture, iconographic attribute, patron, site context, and cross-site comparison - and this method, applied rigorously to Khajuraho's figural corpus, is what separates a description ("erotic sculptures exist at Khajuraho") from an analytical argument ("Khajuraho's sculptural programme uses dynamic posture and comprehensive subject range to embody a comprehensive vision of sacred and secular life").

2. Advanced vocabulary

Term	Precise meaning
FACT: Aniconic-to-iconic argument	Early Buddhist programmes frequently represented the Buddha through symbols; anthropomorphic images emerged in Gandhara and Mathura in broadly overlapping early-CE contexts. Avoid treating either school as the uncontested sole origin.
FACT: Tribhanga posture	A "three-bend" body posture (used extensively at Amaravati, and seen in the Harappan Dancing Girl) conveying dynamism and grace - a specific, namable posture rather than generic "graceful pose" (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF pp. 192, 204).
ANALYSIS: Iconographic attribute reading (avayudha method)	Reading a Hindu deity's identity through carried attribute/symbol (Shiva through linga, Vishnu through specific avatars) rather than through inscription alone - the Mathura school's signature interpretive technique, reusable wherever an unlabelled sculpture must be identified.
FACT: Chronological correction technique	Using the Ravana Phadi Cave Nataraja (early Chalukya) to correct the common assumption that Chola patronage originated, rather than perfected, Nataraja iconography (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF p. 211) - a model for how advanced answers should distinguish "origin" from "peak development."

3. Comparative framework

Case	Material/technique	Posture/gesture	Patron/site	Comparative point
FACT: Nataraja (Chola bronze)	Cire-perdue bronze	Tandava, bhujangatrasita leg stance, multiple symbolic hand gestures	Chola temples (Chidambaram, Thanjavur)	Peak development of an Aihole-originated (Chalukya) iconographic form
FACT: Khajuraho figural sculpture	Sandstone relief, often high relief	Dynamic, flexed, multi-postured figures across sacred, courtly and everyday registers	Chandella (topic 03)	"Resilient vigour" = rhythmic modelling; "breadth of life" = subject-range comprehensiveness
FACT: Gandhara Buddha	Grey stone/stucco	Static, serene, Greco-Roman-influenced drapery	Kushana patronage	Contrast: composed stillness vs. Khajuraho/Chola dynamism
FACT: Mathura Yaksha (Parkham)	Red sandstone	Frontal, monumental, "massive strength and gravity" (<i>Nitin...pdf</i> , PDF p. 198)	Mauryan-period popular cult	Early precedent for the scale and physical presence later seen in temple sculpture

4. Evidence, form and interpretation

FACT: Applying the six-factor method to the 2025 PYQ's Chandella phrase: **material** (fine-grained sandstone permitting deep, precise relief carving); **posture/gesture** (dynamic, twisting figures - dancers, musicians, mithuna couples - rather than static frontal poses); **iconographic attribute** (Vyalas as a specific recurring hybrid-animal motif, distinct from a generic "decorative animal"); **patron** (Chandella royal and elite patronage under an independent dynasty, topic 03); **site context** (open platforms without enclosure walls, unlike the walled Dravida temple complexes); **cross-site comparison** (Khajuraho's sculptural density is comparable to, but not identical in programme to, Hoysala's stellate-platform friezes or Chola bronze icon-making) - together these six factors substantiate "resilient vigour" (posture dynamism) and "breadth of life" (programme comprehensiveness) as evidence-based claims rather than paraphrase of the question. ANALYSIS: The book's own chronological correction on Nataraja (Aihole origin, Chola peak) models the discipline an advanced answer needs: never assume the dynasty most famous for a form also originated it.

5. Visual synthesis table

SIX-FACTOR SCULPTURE-READING METHOD

material -> posture/gesture -> iconographic attribute ->
patron -> site context -> cross-site comparison
|
v

APPLIED TO KHAJURAHO (2025 PYQ):

sandstone (precise relief) + dynamic multi-posture figures +
Vyalas/Tantric imagery + Chandella patronage + unenclosed
terraces + comparison with Hoysala/Chola = evidence-based
"resilient vigour and breadth of life"

6. Direct-book source spine

FACT: *Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 197-198 (Yaksha/Yakshi, Parkham/Didarganj), PDF pp. 200-204 (Gandhara/Mathura/Amaravati comparison), PDF pp. 210-212 (Nataraja iconography and its Aihole origin), cross-referenced to PDF pp. 80-81 (Khajuraho sculptural programme, topic 03).

7. CURRENT: Dated official anchor

- CURRENT: No urgent current-status correction is required for this topic's

core iconographic claims (Nataraja iconography, Gandhara/Mathura/ Amaravati classification are stable scholarly consensus); any claim about a *specific* sculpture's current museum location or repatriation status should be checked against the relevant museum's or ASI's own dated release before citation (see topic 14's repatriation-caution note).

8. Exact PYQ application

FACT: **2025 Q3 (Chandella sculpture), advanced support:** apply the six-factor method (Section 4) to structure a topic-03 answer with explicit evidentiary categories rather than adjective-heavy description. ANALYSIS: No Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers tests sculpture/ pottery/iconography as a stand-alone topic; this file's contribution is entirely in strengthening topic 03's and topic 09's answers.

9. WRONG: Attribution, chronology and numeric traps

- WRONG: Treating Chola patronage as the origin of Nataraja iconography. -> The

book places its earliest known example at Aihole under the early Chalukyas; advanced answers must make this origin/peak distinction explicitly.

- WRONG: Treating "Indo-Greek" (Gandhara) as meaning the sculpture is

literally Greek art without Indian content. -> It is a Buddhist iconographic and doctrinal programme executed with Hellenistic/ Parthian/Central Asian stylistic influence - content and style must be distinguished.

- WRONG: Assuming iconographic attribute identification always over-rides

contextual/inscriptional evidence. -> Use avayudha/attribute reading as a *supporting* method, not a substitute for an available inscription or documented provenance.

- WRONG: Treating traditional museum labels as decoded Harappan identities. ->

"Pashupati," "Mother Goddess" and "Priest-King" are hypotheses or conveniences, not readings from the undeciphered script.

- WRONG: Assigning Didarganj automatically to the Mauryas. -> Its polish supports

that attribution, but stylistic and chronological arguments for later dating remain; state the debate.

10. Mains answer frameworks

Central thesis: Indian sculpture should be argued through the six-factor method (material, posture, attribute, patron, site, comparison), which converts descriptive praise into evidence-based analysis - most powerfully demonstrated by applying it to Khajuraho's "resilient vigour and breadth of life" and to the Nataraja's Aihole-to-Chola developmental arc.

1. **Never open with generic praise** ("India has a rich sculptural tradition") - open with the specific school/dynasty/site.
2. **Apply the six-factor method explicitly**, naming each factor.
3. **Use the Nataraja origin/peak distinction** as a model whenever a question risks conflating a form's originator with its most famous patron.

4. **Cross-reference topic 03's Chandella dossier** for the fullest application of this method to a single case.

5. **Close with a comparison** (Gandhara vs. Mathura, or Khajuraho vs. Hoysala/Chola) to demonstrate comparative fluency.

11. Subject boundaries

- WRONG: **Topic 13 owns** the doctrinal/theological significance of iconographic attributes (e.g. what Shiva's Tandava *means* in Shaiva philosophy). This file owns the **art-historical reading method** only.

- WRONG: **Ancient/Medieval History owns** the political chronology of the Kushana, Satavahana and Chola periods in depth.

- FACT: This file's six-factor method is directly reusable for topic 03's advanced Chandella dossier and topic 07's painting-analysis method.

12. Companion links

- FACT: Foundation companion: basic/06_Sculpture-Pottery-and-Iconography.md.

- FACT: 00_Master-Framework.md Section 2 - the "how to read a monument, artwork or performance" method this file's six-factor approach extends.

- ANALYSIS: **Cross-links:** Topic 03 (Chandella sculptural-programme dossier, the primary application of this file's method), Topic 09 (shared postures/mudras between sculpture and dance).

13. Verification ledger and open cautions

- FACT: Verified against *Nitin...pdf*, PDF pp. 189-214 directly.

- ANALYSIS: Open caution: this file's cross-reference to Khajuraho sculpture (topic 03) relies on that topic's own page citations (PDF pp. 80-81); no separate iconography-specific passage on Khajuraho beyond what topic 03 already cites was independently verified in this chapter.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2019, 2022

- **Paper(s):** GS-I

- **Routed question demands:** 3

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2019	GS-I	1	Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art	Highlight · 10 marks · 150 words	Cross-cutting; art form and Kushana contact both linked	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-I	1	Medieval Indian temple sculptures as evidence of social life	How will you explain · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-I	13	Lion and bull figures in Indian mythology art and architecture	Discuss the significance · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art
- Medieval Indian temple sculptures as evidence of social life
- Lion and bull figures in Indian mythology art and architecture

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Six-variable reading rail

MATERIAL -> what carving or casting permits
POSTURE + ATTRIBUTE -> identity and action
PATRON + SITE -> commissioned context
COMPARISON -> similarity, difference and limit
MUST REMEMBER: Sculpture and pottery must be read through material, technique, posture, attribute, patron and site, from lost-wax casting and pottery sequences to Gandhara, Mathura, Amaravati, Gupta and Chola visual programmes.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: Lost-wax and label firewall

WAX MODEL -> clay investment
HEAT -> wax leaves a cavity
MOLTEN METAL -> bronze form
MEANING -> separate from a museum label

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: Pottery chronology

NEOLITHIC -> coarse hand-made ware
CHALCOLITHIC -> Ahar, Malwa and Jorwe painted wares
HARAPPAN / PGW -> separate chronological markers
NBPW -> fine early historic tableware

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Three-school matrix

GANDHARA -> grey stone, Buddhist, layered influence
MATHURA -> red stone, three religions, attributes
AMARAVATI -> limestone, Buddhist narrative, tribhanga
RULE -> compare on the same axes

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: Aniconic to iconic

EMPTY THRONE / TREE / WHEEL -> symbolic presence
DEVOTIONAL CHANGE -> human image becomes central
GANDHARA + MATHURA -> overlapping early-CE contexts
CAUTION -> no uncontested sole origin

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: Gupta bridge

SARNATH -> cream sandstone
BODY -> subtle modelling and thin drapery
SULTANGANJ -> late or post-Gupta caution
BRIDGE -> restraint before denser temple programmes

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: Nataraja chronology

AIHOLE -> early known antecedent
CHOLA -> canonical portable bronze
TEMPLE PROCESSION -> ritual mobility
RULE -> peak is not origin

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: Nataraja attribute map

DAMARU / FIRE -> creation and destruction
ABHAYA / RAISED FOOT -> reassurance and release
APASMARA -> ignorance subdued
AUREOLE -> recurring time

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: Lion-bull evidence ladder

HARAPPAN -> bull visible, meaning unrecoverable
RAMPURVA -> inscribed lion, uninscribed bull
SARNATH -> animals inside a Buddhist-imperial system
TEMPLE -> Nandi, Yali and Vyala gain placed roles

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: Temple animal placement

NANDI -> axial pavilion before Shiva
YALI -> composite guardian on southern pillars
VYALA -> lion-bodied hybrid at Khajuraho
DISTINCTION -> building, guardian and motif
CLOSE DISTINCTION: Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati differ by material, religious scope and visual grammar; symbolic Buddha representation preceded broadly overlapping Gandhara-Mathura iconic production, so sole-origin claims are unsafe.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Social-evidence test

FIGURE -> dancer, musician, teacher or couple
PATRON -> selected what became visible
CLAIM -> valued activity or ritual idiom
LIMIT -> not a census of society
EVIDENCE LIMIT: Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King are modern Harappan labels; Chola bronzes canonised rather than originated Nataraja, and temple sculpture records patron-selected visibility rather than a social census.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: Sculpture answer spine

DEFINE -> school, object or symbol

EVIDENCE -> material, posture, attribute and site

COMPARE -> period or regional workshop

QUALIFY -> attribution, priority and social inference